Feminist Art Manifestos An Anthology

Katy Deepwell(ed) KT press

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Katy Deepwell (editor)

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ABOUT KT PRESS BOOKS

NEGOTIATIONS

KATY DEEPWELL

What is a manifesto? A political programme, a declaration, a definitive statement of belief. Neither institutional mission statement, nor religious dogma; neither a poem, nor a book. As a form of literature, manifestos occupy a specific place in the history of public discourse as a means to communicate radical ideas. Distributed as often ephemeral documents, as leaflets or pamphlets in political campaigns or as announcements of the formation of new parties or new avant-gardes, manifestos above all declare what its authors are for and against, and ask people who read them to join them, to understand, to share these ideas. The feminist art manifestos in this anthology do all of these things as they explore the potential and possibilities of women's cultural production as visual artists.

I first compiled a list of feminist manifestos for *n.paradoxa: international feminist art journal*'s website in preparation for a seminar I organised at the ICA in London in 2011. Many of these manifestos were available online, but not all: four of them I had published earlier in n.paradoxa. I started hunting for manifestos to add to the list and quickly found more that had been published or distributed but weren't well known or easily available. The ICA seminar was based on reading these manifestos collectively and out loud as I thought they should be spoken and shared in a group rather than read quietly and alone. Bringing them together created an opportunity to discuss the changes within feminist cultural politics and different forms of feminist poetics over the last forty years. Evident within these manifestos are different forms of relationships between feminist politics as a set of "demands" and feminist art practices and poetics. They can also be read as experiments in feminist aesthetics focused on women artists' subjectivity, expression and creative potential.

Arranging them into a chronological list underlined the fact that women artists had continued to produce manifestos, beyond the earliest moments of the women's liberation movement in 1968, and that each of these manifestos presents distinct and specific qualities in terms of when they were written and how they express their ideas. While there has been an academic tendency to "confine" the politics of feminism and feminist art practices to the 1970s or to an Anglo-American dynamic, this collection reveals that this was not the case. Reading across these manifestos makes the shifting paths within feminism visible, paths which demonstrate what the movement has represented to artists working in many different parts of the world since the late 1960s. The order of this ebook keeps the chronology in which these manifestos were written to encourage readers to consider this history, which is not a simple linear development or progression. Like *n.paradoxa*, which I founded and edit, this selection affirms the broad international dynamic to what has been achieved over the last forty years in feminism as well as its very different threads of enquiry.

When I first compiled this feminist manifesto list in 2010, I gathered together many early feminist political manifestos from anarchist, radical separatist, left-wing and red stocking politics over the last forty years, as well as some early feminist and futurist manifestos from the 1910s. This relationship between the politics of art and the politics of feminism is not insignificant and for those who wish to

consider this further, some other feminist political manifestos are listed after this introduction.

This collection concentrates on manifestos which are about feminist art production and film-making by feminist artists. I felt that a separate collection on feminist art manifestos was necessary as all too often the same three or four feminist manifestos are reproduced in either manifesto collections or anthologies of artists' writings. The most famous, even infamous, and widely reproduced is Valerie Solanas' *SCUM manifesto*, which I took the decision not to seek to reproduce as it is widely available in print and online: similarly Yvonne Rainer's classic 'No Manifesto' on contemporary dance practices and Donna Haraway's 'Manifesto for Cyborgs' are also widely reproduced. These are three very important feminist texts, but there are many other forms of feminist art manifesto. I was inspired by Janet Lyons' book on manifestos as 'Provocations of the Modern', which does not avoid discussing the poetics and politics of feminism and offers many very insightful points about how manifestos frame their arguments. Her chosen examples were Jenny Holzer's multi-media work *Truisms* (which has been a poster, T-shirts, as well as an artwork presented in LED displays in public spaces and large scale outdoor light projections, 1977-present) and the manifestos/ handbooks of The Lesbian Avengers from the 1990s. Through these examples, Lyons draws a relationship between early avant-garde politics and poetics and contemporary feminism.

In this collection, none of the texts are identical in approach, content or poetics. They each arise from different historical moments and express widely divergent political views. If they share anything, it would have to be defined very loosely by a common concern for women's art practices, feminist politics and women's creative potential as artists. The writing embraces many different kinds of poetics, modes of address and values as well as pursuing different topics from care, love and sexuality, to witchcraft and cyberfeminism, from aspirations for the future to ideas about creativity (known and unknown).

The last forty years have witnessed an explosion of different forms of feminism from the early politics of women's liberation – which was itself a very broad alliance of different social, cultural and political groupings – to calls for affirmative action; to equal opportunities in cultural politics; to ecofeminisms; to cyberfeminisms; to lesbian feminisms and to Afro-futurist feminisms. Feminism is a dynamic politics and the singularity of this term has always covered a broad range of political opinions: liberal, left-wing, right-wing, radical, anarchist, separatist, cyberfeminist and eco-feminist. Nevertheless feminism has been resolutely anti-sexist, anti-racist, anti-homophobic, anti-ageist, anti-capitalist and anti-Imperialist. In varying degrees and in different kinds of politics, it has spoken for separatism (in women's publications, groups and exhibitions), for wider recognition of women's cultural production, for new forms of collaboration between women and for collective action by women to demand change.

If a manifesto is a political declaration or a statement for and against certain positions, tendencies and beliefs, then what is being declared in this collection? Each of these manifestos announce a different critique of the *status quo*, of patriarchy and currently proscribed roles for men and women in our society, including the very limited, often dismissive, view of the woman artist. Against this negative position and the stereotyping or stigmatising view of both femininity and female creativity, each proceeds to announce and affirm what women's creativity has been, is and might become given the current cultural and political situation. As well as analysis, there is much utopian thinking in these declarations. These manifestos importantly open a space for the future of women's creative art practices – without filling it with any single didactic programme. Where they do announce a programme or a broader scope for future work they affirm a new and creative beginning of what might be possible for women artists, for art and for feminist

politics.

Manifestos were one of the principal documents through which the avant-gardes of the early twentieth century announced their artistic position, and they are routinely republished and studied as a feature of avant-garde art practices, especially those around the modern art movements of Dadaism, Futurism and Surrealism. Women's contributions to this modernist genre are often overlooked, especially the early manifestos of Valentine de Saint Point and Mina Loy. Feminism has had its own internal debates about whether it is an avant-garde movement post-1968 in the field of contemporary art or not, whether it exhibits avant-gardism in both politics and practice or should be considered instead in terms of a more broadly conceived politics of cultural interventions and change. This is because feminism is not an art style, a brand, a fashion trend or a recognisable artistic category known as "women's art" or "feminist art", nor is it centred around images of "the body" aka "women's bodies". There are many who have argued against forms of avant-gardism within feminism (regarding what was the women's art movement as a broad collective movement and against any conception of a unified style or set of concerns). Others have advanced the argument that any feminist cultural politics represents a strong critique of the historical avant-garde, its political tactics or ways of politically organising resistance, and this is why feminism cannot be considered an avant-garde, even as an alternative. Yet there are others who regard feminism as the last true avant-garde movement in the twentieth century. In so far as the manifestos in this book indicate differences between women historically and politically, this anthology confirms the complexity of these historical relations and political questions. Collecting together these manifestos should provide a means to explore the strong links between feminist art production and feminist politics regarding social change.

Within the anthology, there are many references to earlier manifestos in terms of the writing style used and in how a position is declared. Arahmaiani's 'Letter to Marinetti', for example, references the style of his Futurist manifesto; Mette Ingvartsen's 'Yes Manifesto' operates a deliberate inversion of Rainer's 'No Manifesto' and the 100 Anti-theses of the Old Boys Network Cyberfeminist Manifesto aim to be as rhetorical and controversial as Martin Luther's ninety-five 'Theses on Religion'. Ramedes' 'SCUB manifesto', as well as Martine Sym's opening line about women's boredom and irritation, echo in different ways Valerie Solanas' *SCUM Manifesto*, which begins with the sentence:

> 'Life in this society being, at best, an utter bore and no aspect of society being at all relevant to women, there remains to civic-minded, responsible, thrill-seeking females only to overthrow the government, eliminate the money system, institute complete automation, and destroy the male sex.'

While Solanas' position on destruction of the male sex is not advocated by any of these manifestos, their critique of patriarchy is inseparable from a feminist vision for the future. Patriarchy is analysed in many different terms across the anthology: it is not simply men against women nor is feminism here the sexist caricature of it as seeking an inverted society where women take precedence over men. While the specific term "oppression" frequently arises in the manifestos from the 1970s, a critique of patriarchy as a social system and a way of thinking which privileges men over women in society is present in most of these texts. Feminist critiques of patriarchy argue that patriarchy is a system of social organisation which has produced women's oppression as a group, suppressed women's knowledge and former culture (a matriarchy), reinforced the exploitation of women in capitalism as second-class and low-paid waged labourers and failed to recognise their value as unwaged workers (as mothers and carers): see, for

example, Nancy Spero, Rita Mae Brown, Anne Berg and Monica Sjoo. Patriarchy, as both a social system and a way of thinking, has over-determined the position of women in art, in culture, in capitalism and in globalisation and produced the objectification of women in mass media, as bodies seen and not heard, or as Rita Mae Brown puts it 'pornography or nostalgia'. With the rise of different forms of identity politics and the critique of essentialist thinking within feminism from the late 1970s onwards, feminists have used the term "oppression" less often, but when they do, they are referring back to this critique of patriarchy and how women's position in society is over-determined by misogynist thinking about women.

Feminist analysis of patriarchy has led women to many different forms of analysis about the position of women in relation to the state and religion. It has put forward a political defence of the earth and the weak and the vulnerable exploited by capitalism, by globalisation, by sexism, by heterosexism, by racism, classism, ageism and by imperialism. Feminism's agenda for social change has been about the transformation of what it means to be human. This means changing the lives of both men and women in our society by escaping all proscribed or stereotyped roles. Feminism here is not limited to the question of legal, social and civil rights, important as these are: instead, many of these texts recognise how practices in everyday life, in cultural representations and in the representation of women as cultural producers can reinforce sexism. Many of these texts also affirm women's rights as human rights and point to the fact that without women's rights, you cannot have any real conception of human rights: see Arahmaiani or Women Artists of Pakistan and Yes Association!.

These manifestos offer new and distinct views of what women artists' creativity will consist of in the future: see, for example, Carolee Schneemann's 'Woman in the Year 2000' (written in 1977); SubRosa's 'REFUGIA' and in VALIE EXPORT's 'Women's Art' or 'Women Artists of Pakistan'. Berg and Sjoo's rejection of middle-class mores and the dominant culture of abstraction in the galleries of the 1970s is accompanied by the question: 'HOW DOES ONE COMMUNICATE WOMEN'S STRENGTH, STRUGGLE, RISING UP FROM OPPRESSION, BLOOD, CHILDBIRTH, SEXUALITY'? Even if we cannot predict what women will produce in the future, we do know that, if their contribution is recognised, if their education is transformed, what they will produce will be something unexpected, different and positive in its own terms. Maria Klonaris and Katerina Thomadaki, for example, argue in their manifesto about other cinema that it is simultaneously a claim for women's autonomy, for independent thinking and creation, and a new form of cinema removed from the fantastic projections about women's culture or "otherness" written about or understood by men. SubRosa advance a 'post-modern commons', a space for new forms of hybridity and possibility to emerge, while Julie Perini outlines her philosophy for a new form of relational film-making between director and subject, process and result.

Manifestos are often considered ephemeral documents. Some circulate only as flyers, posters, press-releases or web pages. In this anthology, a few of these "manifestos" were produced as artworks (Dora Garcia, Lucia Tkacova/Anneta Mona Chisa) and those of Carolee Schneemann, Ewa Partum, and Yes Association! developed from or as texts spoken in performances. The language of speech, of declaration and of performance is present in, for example, Silvia Ziranek and Martine Syms and of poetry and aphorisms in Agnes Denes or Lily Bea Moor (aka Senga Nengudi). Some of these statements existed as catalogue essays or announcements such as Mierle Ukeles, Orlan, or Violetta Liagatchev. Other manifestos have circulated exclusively on the web, like the work of VNS Matrix or Stephen and Sprinkle.

Many kinds of poetics emerge in how these different documents are written, but it is notable how frequently repetition, bullet points or lists are used to express the complexity and multiplicity of position.

The most concise is the most collectively authored, the Womanifesto from 1975, approved and signed by 80 women. Reversal, irony or humour are often strategically deployed in these manifestos, see VNS Matrix or The Guerrilla Girls or Tkacova and Chisa for example. A position is affirmed even when the manifesto itself states only negative terms or a list of refusals, as in the Old Boys Network's 'Cyberfeminist Manifesto'. What might become possible is affirmed by listing impossibilities, as in Dora Garcia's text, or a long list of what feminism is not, evident in First Manifesto on the Cultural Revolution of Women or in Martine Syms on Afro-Futurism.

A manifesto remains the ultimate political propaganda document announcing programmes for social and political change and condensing declarations of moral and political belief into graspable slogans. Such documents in political life are repeatedly revised and produced by political parties, including marginal and alternative groups, and their aspirations are increasingly echoed in the mission statements of NGOs. Although I came across some very interesting founding statements of feminist art groups – from the Sirens group in China as they launched their gallery/ studio in the 1990s, or Pecha Blenda in the 2010s, or La Sal in Spain in the 1970s – these were more often programmatic mission statements rather than manifestos. The Feminist Art Gallery in Toronto's slogan, produced as an artwork in crochet, was 'WE CAN'T COMPETE/WE WON'T COMPETE / WE CAN'T KEEP UP/ WE WON'T KEEP DOWN'. Women artists' groups have been numerous in the second half of the twentieth century and into the twenty-first century.

In this bureaucratic age, the need to declare what you are about and what you represent in a mission statement is distinct as a mode of address from the appeal of a manifesto to encourage people to join you in a cause or subscribe to your ideas. The few founding statements are included because they attempted to signal a new type of politics (see Feminist Art Action Brigade (FAAB), or Women Artists of Pakistan or Factory of Found Clothes (FFC)) even when some of these alliances ultimately proved to be temporary. In the case of Eva and Co., ironically their manifesto announces the dissolution of their group, but its list of refusals to be co-opted as yet another artists' group within the art world signal the difficulties of keeping going – in terms of the life-span of a group and competing commitments – even when success is achieved. Other kinds of cultural politics, arising from collaborations between women, are signalled in Chila Burman and in Anne Berg and Monica Sjoo's statements, even though their tactics and their arguments are separated by more than twenty years and their philosophies or political critiques could not be more different.

Many feminist manifestos from Mina Loy to Carla Lonzi have warned that feminism has never been only about equality and that believing feminism will end when some form of equality in numbers has been reached is an illusion which will not change sexism or patriarchal thinking. Like these two writers, many feminists question whether equality between the sexes is feminism's only or ultimate goal. Nevertheless, several of these manifestos refer to how quotas will be necessary to change the representation of women artists in our exhibitions and museums. Women artists are not a minority amongst all artists. They remain a minority group only because of the selection procedures of exhibitions and the practices of criticism and art history where gender remains a decisive, often tacit, factor in how discrimination operates. Too often discussion of gender (which is both male/female, masculinity/femininity) is sidelined and regarded as irrelevant to the processes of the selective tradition, which filter and discriminate the many into the few, or in the collecting practices of museums and collectors who feed off the knowledge generated by the same selective tradition in their pursuit of "the best". WSABAL's statement in 1970 was incredibly

radical and forward-thinking in its insistence on levels of representation for women, and particularly for black women artists, in open exhibitions in New York. Its distribution sparked debate; it was a provocation and a call to action. Many have followed this attempt to represent women artists at levels appropriate to their existence in the population (52%) and to insist on representation according to population, including all ethnic minorities and religious minorities. The same critique arises in more detail in Chila Burman's essay 'Why have there been no great black women artists?' (1987) which took up the question Linda Nochlin raised in 1971 and turns it to an analysis of the discrimination against women artists from ethnic minorities in the UK, particularly in art schools, and in how these artists and their work were often judged in limited and stereotyped ways.

The ARCO manifesto (2005) arose in a very different moment in a series of public debates about feminism held in a large talks programme at an art fair. As such, it was directed at museum directors' and collectors' acquisition policies. By repeating the Guerrilla Girls early poster: 'What will your collection be worth when sexism and racism are no longer fashionable?', it also acted as a provocation for future work and was signed by many leading feminist curators and art historians in Europe and the USA. In Sweden, which many regard as a model for social democratic practices which uphold equality between the sexes, Yes Association!'s agreement was prompted and facilitated by the opening of a feminist exhibition at which the group could present a detailed analysis of institutionalised discrimination in museums against women artists. Utilising the language of contract law, the equal opportunities agreement which they initiated was an attempt to counteract institutionalised discrimination against women artists and encourage museums to make a commitment to equal opportunities indefinitely into the future. The aim of such a document is to create a dialogue which will change the unequal representation of women artists which can be easily and objectively measured in numbers. However, as Silvia Ziranek states, we need: 'MORE QUALITY THROUGH FEMALE QUANTITY'. Tkacova and Chisa's text, produced by two women artists invited to represent their country in a biennale, wittily weighs up what this stake in national representation will mean for them and their work as emerging artists, using Pareto's 80/20 principle. This contrasts with earlier texts like Berg and Sjoo which in the 1970s questioned whether the gallery system would ever provide recognition for women given the marked discrimination against them. Representation in numerical strength is only one part of countering discrimination and injustices in distribution of wealth and of goods: as Nancy Fraser has argued, recognition is also key.

Recognition for the work that women do and the value of that work arises again and again in this anthology. The tension between development and maintenance is central to Mierle Laderman Ukeles' 'Manifesto for Maintenance Art'. Maintenance work is often invisible, repetitive and unrewarding. It is even conceived of as the anti-thesis to Art, if this is held up to be the epitome of free intellectual labour determined by a creative individual. Ukeles' radical reconsideration of economics and ecology, literally how we deal with questions of production and waste, of what is cared for or disregarded in our society, radically transformed this maintenance labour into Art. The question of reproduction of the conditions for production remains the most neglected question in political and economic debates which remain focused on production of goods, not services and waged labour. Women's labour patterns have changed in the new service-based economies and in globalised domestic markets since the 1960s. Women's role in reproduction – through motherhood, in care for the sick and elderly, extended family and for the vulnerable in the community, in education and in the general maintenance of our society – nevertheless still regularly disappears from view in public debates. Withdrawing this reproductive, developmental and maintenance labour would bring capitalism to its knees, because it has been so fundamental to its

continuation. From this analysis of unwaged labour came the idea of women striking from housework, both as a protest against the situation of women and for recognition of the contribution of this work to a wage labour economy.

The work of education is referred to in many of these manifestos as a positive force for change in women's opportunities. The potential to offer different curricula and a different set of values has been at the heart of feminist teaching. Budapest, Rosenbach and Coven's manifesto looks back to matriarchy, to magic for an affirmation of a different kind of value system for feminism. The persecution of witches became symbols for modern feminists of the persecution of women's traditions and the suppression of their knowledge by the modern church and state in patriarchal forms of religious practice, where men came to hold authority over the congregation. As they suggest: 'when we are fighting for the right to control our own bodies, it is also time to fight for the well-being of our souls.' The right to fight all forms of superstition, cant and prejudice is also reaffirmed in the Women Artists of Pakistan Manifesto alongside the need to 'respect and uphold the right of every woman artist to her own faith, her individual approach to content, form, medium, method, technique and style in the realisation of her artistic ideals'.

The continued importance of feminism, in different contexts and in forms of collective feminist cultural politics, is affirmed in the production of each of these manifestos. The imagination, reinvention and affirmation visible in these brief documents is, for me, the most optimistic message in the manifestos and why they should be known more widely and read as inspiration and encouragement to artists everywhere. This anthology was only made possible by the generous agreement of all the authors/ artists who shared the understanding that collecting together and distributing these statements/ manifestos would prove worthwhile to renew, reconsider and continue feminist cultural politics in the future. I want to thank them for their work.

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RIOT GRRRL MANIFESTO. The Riot Grrrl Movement began in the early 1990s by Washington State band Bikini Kill and lead singer Kathleen Hanna.

Natasha Vita-More 'Extropic Art Manifesto of Transhumanist Arts' (1997)

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MANIFESTO FOR MAINTENANCE ART 1969!
Proposal for an exhibition *CARE*

MIERLE LADERMAN UKELES

I. IDEAS:

A. The Death Instinct and the Life Instinct:

The Death Instinct: separation; individuality; Avant-Garde par excellence; to follow one's own path to death — do your own thing; dynamic change.

The Life Instinct: unification; the eternal return; the perpetuation and MAINTENANCE of the species; survival systems and operations; equilibrium.

B. Two basic systems: Development and Maintenance. The sourball of every revolution: after the revolution, who's going to pick up the garbage on Monday morning?

Development: pure individual creation; the new; change; progress; advance; excitement; flight or fleeing.

Maintenance: keep the dust off the pure individual creation; preserve the new; sustain the change; protect progress; defend and prolong the advance; renew the excitement; repeat the flight;

show your work — show it again

keep the contemporaryartmuseum groovy

keep the home fires burning

Development systems are partial feedback systems with major room for change.

Maintenance systems are direct feedback systems with little room for alteration.

C. Maintenance is a drag; it takes all the fucking time (lit.) The mind boggles and chafes at the boredom.The culture confers lousy status on maintenance jobs = minimum wages, housewives = no pay.

clean your desk, wash the dishes, clean the floor, wash your clothes, wash your toes, change the baby's diaper, finish the report, correct the typos, mend the fence, keep the customer happy, throw out the stinking garbage, watch out don't put things in your nose, what shall I wear, I have no sox, pay your bills, don't litter, save string, wash your hair,

change the sheets,go to the store, I'm out of perfume, say it again — he doesn't understand, seal it again — it leaks, go to work, this art is dusty, clear the table, call him again, flush the toilet, stay young.

D. Art:

Everything I say is Art is Art. Everything I do is Art is Art.
"We have no Art, we try to do everything well." (Balinese saying).

Avant-garde art, which claims utter development, is infected by strains of maintenance ideas, maintenance activities,and maintenance materials. Conceptual & Process art, especially, claim pure development and change, yet employ almost purely maintenance processes.

E. The exhibition of Maintenance Art, *CARE*, would zero in on pure maintenance, exhibit it as contemporary art, and yield, by utter opposition, clarity of issues.

II. THE MAINTENANCE ART EXHIBITION: *CARE*

Three parts: Personal, General, and Earth Maintenance.

A. Part One: Personal

I am an artist. I am a woman. I am a wife.

I am a mother. (Random order).

I do a hell of a lot of washing, cleaning, cooking, renewing, supporting, preserving, etc. Also, (up to now separately) I "do" Art.

Now, I will simply do these maintenance everyday things, and flush them up to consciousness, exhibit them, as Art. I will live in the museum and I customarily do at home with my husband and my baby, for the duration of the exhibition.(Right? or if you don't want me around at night I would come in every day) and do all these things as public Art activities: I will sweep and wax the floors, dust everything, wash the walls (i.e. "floor paintings, dust works, soap-sculpture, wall-paintings") cook, invite people to eat, make agglomerations and dispositions of all functional refuse.

The exhibition area might look "empty" of art, but it will be maintained in full public view.

MY WORKING WILL BE THE WORK

B. Part Two: General

Everyone does a hell of a lot of noodling maintenance work. The general part of the

exhibition would consist of interviews of two kinds.

1. Previous individual interviews, typed and exhibited.

Interviewees come from, say, 50 different classes and kinds of occupations that run a gamut from maintenance “man”, maid, sanitation “man”, mail “man”, union “man”, construction worker, librarian, grocerystore “man”, nurse, doctor, teacher, museum director, baseball player, sales "man”, child, criminal, bank president, mayor, moviestar, artist, etc., about:

- what you think maintenance is;

- how you feel about spending whatever parts of your life you spend on maintenance activities;

- what is the relationship between maintenance and freedom;

- what is the relationship between maintenance and life’s dreams.

2. Interview Room — for spectators at the Exhibition:

A room of desks and chairs where professional (?) interviewers will interview the spectators at the exhibition along same questions as typed interviews. The responses should be personal.

These interviews are taped and replayed throughout the exhibition area.

C. Part Three: Earth Maintenance

Everyday, containers of the following kinds of refuse will be delivered to the Museum:

- the contents of one sanitation truck;

- a container of polluted air;

- a container of polluted Hudson River;

- a container of ravaged land.

Once at the exhibition, each container will be serviced:

purified, de-polluted, rehabilitated, recycled, and conserved by various technical (and / or pseudo-technical) procedures either by myself or scientists.

These servicing procedures are repeated throughout the duration of the exhibition.

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Reproduced in Lucy Lippard *Six Years: The Dematerialisation of the Art Object from 1966-1972* (New York: Praeger, 1973); reprinted in same title (New York: New York University Press, 1979). Part I is reproduced in Kristine Stiles and Peter Selz (eds.) *Theories and Documents of Contemporary Art, A Sourcebook of Artists' Writings* (University of California Press, 1996).
This version from Ronald Feldman Gallery, New York website. Courtesy of Ronald Feldman Fine Arts, New York and Artist.
Also published on Arnolfini Gallery, Bristol blog on the occasion of her one-person international touring exhibition, *Mierle Laderman Ukeles, Maintenance Art Works 1969-1980*, in September-November 2013.
Mierle Ukeles also wrote ‘Sanitation Manifesto’ (1984) reproduced in Kristine Stiles and Peter Selz (eds.) *Theories and Documents of Contemporary Art* (1996).

A MANIFESTO (1969)

AGNES DENES

Working with a paradox

defining the elusive

visualizing the invisible

communicating the incommunicable

not accepting the limitations society has accepted

seeing in new ways

living for a fraction of a second and penetrating light years
measuring time in the extreme distances –
long before and beyond living existence

using intellect and instinct to achieve intuition

striving to surpass human limitations by searching the mysteries
and probing the silent universe,
alive with hidden creativity

achieving total self-consciousness and self-awareness

probing to locate the center of things –
the true inner core of inherent but not yet understood meaning –
and expose it to be analyzed

being creatively obsessive

questioning, reasoning, analyzing, dissecting and re-examining

understanding that everything has further meaning,
that order has been created out of chaos,
but order, when it reaches a certain totality
must be shattered by new disorder

and by new inquiries and developments

finding new concepts, recognizing new patterns

understanding the finitude of human existence and still striving
to create beauty
and provocative reasoning

recognizing and interpreting the relationship of creative elements
to each other: people to people,
people to god, people to nature, nature to nature, thought to thought, art to art

seeing reality and still being able to dream

desiring to know the importance or insignificance of existence

persisting in the eternal search

Copyright © 1969 Agnes Denes.
Source: Agnes Denes website.
Courtesy Leslie Tonkonow Artworks + Projects, New York.

THE MANIFESTO OF WSABAL
WOMEN STUDENTS AND ARTISTS FOR BLACK ART LIBERATION
A STUDENT ORGANIZATION OF BLACK ART WORKERS (1970)

MICHELLE WALLACE

THE FUNCTIONS OF WSABAL:-

To inform the Student Public of the Esthetic Oppression of Black Women in the Visual Arts

This Esthetic Oppression Comes in the Forms of:

Brown Art shows filled with Token Art Niggas which are being passed off for Black Art Shows.

Anti-Human Art Shows which are being passed off for Protest Shows.

The exclusion of Black Women Artists from ALL shows because of their position as the only generation which is creating A Revolution in Art.

To Encourage All Students to Protest and Challenge All Trends Against Art for People

WSABAL has done this most recently in the cases of:

Letters to the New York Times in response to articles written by Hilton Kramer, "Uncle" Benny Andrews and Edmund Gaither concerning the show - *Afro-American Artists*: New York & Boston - which intentionally excluded black women for the purpose of leading the public to believe that the BROWN SHIT ART done by black male artists was Black Art; and for the purpose of projecting particular Token Art Niggas which do not threaten the Anti-Human Art establishment.

A commitment which was expressed in a letter to Edmund Gaither, the organizer of the Boston Brown Shit Art Show to actively oppose all Brown Art Shows which are meant to oppress all real art in the future.

A demonstration against the Venice Biennale Show at the School of Visual Arts on July 6th at 3:30 p.m. because of its exclusion of women, blacks and black women; and because of its intention to disguise the exhibition as a protest show when it was actually

another implementation of Anti-Human Art and a projection of superstars.
It appears, at least for the moment, that THE EMERGENCY CULTURAL GOVERNMENT COMMITTEE has complied to WSABAL's first demand by making the Venice Biennale Show open.
Notice of this change was not in the papers, nor have we seen it written anywhere.
WSABAL suspects that the arrangement will be the following: The Anti-Human artists will be exhibited in the Gallery, and the black artists and women artists will be exhibited in the lobby. If this be the case, WSABAL will protest this segregation. WSABAL demands that the art works be totally integrated throughout the lobby and the gallery.
WSABAL invites all students to see that the superstars projection of these Anti-Human Artists be stopped.

To Support the Exposure of Real Black Art Which is Done by Black Women Who, As Mothers and Sisters, Are Concerned With the Afro-American Situation of Today

We supply the black women with a liberated voice to protest bigotry on the part of black and white male artists against black women artists.

We are destroying the walls that separate the art of black women from the view of the people by exposing so called black art shows as Brown Shit Art Shows, and so called protest shows as Anti-Human Art Superstar shows.

We are revitalizing an interest in black art among students, outraged by social injustices, and thus we are bringing an end to the disenchantment of ALL students with ALL art.

WSABAL's DEFINITION OF BLACK ART

Black Art is Truth Which Is -

The Black Color of our skin.

Rhythm which is the major black artistic contribution.

An artistic heritage which comes from the Principles of African Art.

The severity of our oppression, our persistent will to survive, and our determination to effect a liberated society.

Black Art is Not:

All Brown Shit (or all male).

"Picture" art.

Political propaganda or prediction of The Future.

Black Art Talk (we don't talk it, we do it).

Token Nigga Art.

Mainstream copy whitey art.

THE MAJOR DEMAND OF WSABAL

ALL GROUP SHOWS ARE TO BE OPENED TO THE PARTICIPATION OF ALL ART WORKERS THROUGHOUT AMERICA

All shows are to be fifty percent women.

All shows which are not a stated projection of a particular cultural group, such as Afro-American, American Indians, American Whites, etc., must reflect the ethnic distribution of the metropolitan area in which the show is being given.

WSABAL'S PRIMARY INTEREST IS IN THE OPPRESSION OF BLACK WOMEN ARTISTS

By Michele Wallace - Art Writer
WSABAL,
Harlem,
New York.

Copyright © Michele Wallace.
WSABAL was the work of artist Faith Ringgold and her daughter, the writer Michele Wallace. By way of introduction, Michele Wallace sent the following statement about WSABAL for this ebook:
'In 1970, Faith Ringgold, my mom and I decided that we needed to found an organization to represent the interests of black feminist artists. Although we were self-identified black feminists, we didn't know many other black women who were. So we founded Women Students and Artists for Black Art Liberation (WSABAL) to cast the umbrella as wide as possible to draw people, male, female, black and white, into our protests and various civil disobedience actions to speak truth to power to the art establishment. The manifesto was composed of the principles of our faith at the time. I wrote the entire text. I was 18 and very radical, or so I thought. My thinking on these and other matters has changed considerably since then as can be observed via *Invisibility Blues* (Verso 1990; 2007); *Dark Designs and Visual Culture* (Duke University Press 2004) and *Black Macho and The Myth of The Superwoman* (The Dial Press 1979; Verso 1990; forthcoming new edition 2015).'

FEMINIST MANIFESTO (c. 1970-1971)

NANCY SPERO

> "…male/female relationships are essentially asymmetrical;
> men dominate women, at least jurally, in all human societies"
> Harold W. Scheffler *Structuralism in Anthropology*
>
> "Papa's little bed pal. Lump of love."
> James Joyce *Ulysses*

The arts, like all areas of activity, are preempted by men. It is male territory governed by the tacit "laws" of male supremacy. Art is always viewed in the aggressive histories of male dominance. As viewed by the male ego, art is masculine. There is no feminine counterpart (even when the arts are considered effete, it is in terms of male effeteness rather than thru so-called over-femininized attributes of delicacy and restraint even if such attributes could be given biological verification.

There are many women artists, many who are well-known, but art itself is viewed as masculine and the product of aggressive male instincts imbued with masculine hero-worship and male-style notoriety. The term "avant-garde" referring as it does to military nomenclature is aggressive-militaristic in origin, and avant-garde notions in art are masculinised versions of revolt, clearly contained within a masculinised status quo.

Women artists are supposed to be servile by training and history. In this male bourgeois social order, a woman is as good as a man, only less so – and her art is as good as a man's, only less so – and those women who are celebrated as artists are celebrated, only less so.

Female museum personnel, female gallery owners and female critics in the characterizations and distributions of contemporary art are even more dominated by sexism than female artists. Feminine inclusion in museum collection exhibitions, gallery groups, etc, is well below 10%. A rapid survey of artists represented in the Whitney Museum collection of American art reveals 8% female, 92% male.

The woman artist demands an autonomy equal to man's. Women artists must rebel against the male caste and economic control (male imperialism is based on a primitive " biological" separation of roles). Women artists are increasingly angry and militant.

In the future there may be feminine or masculine arts, but this will appear under the aegis of some more ultimate liberation. Today there is an art that is a mixture of the history of what has been, a diffused asexual generalized art. This would be fine were it not dominated in all its external manifestations by simplistic male-ego drives.

The ultimate liberation of women is the hardest and most ultimate task of revolution because her biological subordination has been so historical and determined. (The ultimate liberation of men from

repressive and sexist roles is the equally difficult complimentary male task of revolution). It is so deep-rooted in the so-called rhythms of nature that to break with it is to create a virtually new order of creature co-equal to man. Then art will change. This is the future.

But the future is in the future. Women artists today condemn male dominance in a bourgeois society. We condemn male suprematist elitism. Women artists demand the immediate break-up of the repressive, sexist male ego domination of museums, galleries, etc. We demand that equality of movement and opportunity taken for granted by men. We demand a new kind of space, a space free from repression to develop the roles of freedom.

Reproduced in Roel Arkesteijn (ed.) *Codex Spero: Nancy Spero: selected writings and interviews 1950-2008* (Amsterdam: Roma Publications, 2008) pp.52-53.

Courtesy of Nancy Spero Estate.

IMAGES ON WOMANPOWER – ARTS MANIFESTO (1971) (trying to give a rough and necessarily incomplete idea of what we are about)

MONICA SJOO and ANNE BERG

We are the artists of the oppressed peoples.

We as women bear on our shoulders oppression stretching back into the ancient past.

---- WE WERE THE FIRST OPPRESSED ----

We reject the abstract researches, playful gimmicks characteristic of contented and successful solo artists. Although aware that these pursuits are not entirely without purpose and interest, we feel that it is NOT possible as members of an oppressed group – half of the human race – and with powerful means of communication in our hands to sit around playing games with the surface of reality.

We accept that early 20th century artists had to escape from Victorian romantic illusions and embrace reality (beyond illusion) via cubism and collage. Like scientists they were trying to get at the reality of vision on the level of atoms and cell-structures, the light and forms that make up what we consider to be the everyday world. In the early 20th century painters were enthusiastic about technology because it seemed to hold the seeds of the future. Futurism, constructivism sought to explore technological reality – but NOW technology is emerged in a commercialism so obscene and decadent that for artists to embrace such values is beyond our comprehension.

Commercial life is the enemy of art and art cannot accept its visual signs as part of our language. DEATH TO THE PLASTIC CULTURE. Our century has tried to make art a part of reality, but the reality in our culture is cross, exploitative, capitalistic reality and our function as artists should be to expose the sickness of this culture and NOT to embrace it.

Perhaps the only thing that can serve us now is sort of tragic realism which is not expressionism because it is too real.

Nature and Machine cannot live together – the living tissue is ground to dust.. “A small and beautiful child walks thru the blasted scene of disaster – a scene that is atomized and disintegrated by the last convulsions of a society that will not die, but hangs on, desiring to bring everything to dust, amongst violent tombs of sordidity and despair, supermarkets and bingo halls.” Where is the glorious new world of the machine?

Art, like science, must explore the world, attempt to heal it; abstract art now serves the rulling classes because it mystifies reality, it is undangerous, undisturbing – it has become like patterns on the level of interior decoration, the tedious technicalities of advertising. It cannot be used as a tool either exploring

mystical reality or exploring social reality. WE REJECT IT. WE SAY NO TO EMPTY ABSTRACTIONS, to the 'art for art's sake' philosophy of the privileged white middle-class male artworld. WE THE OPPRESSED cannot afford this empty play with words and forms, for us the import and task is to convey to people to WOMEN – their dignity and strength and beauty – OUR PAST AND FUTURE. God-Woman giving birth to the universe out of her bloody womb, life, death, rebirth – the eternal mystery of life and its richness.

HOW DOES ONE COMMUNICATE WOMEN'S STRENGTH, STRUGGLE, RISING UP FROM OPPRESSION, BLOOD, CHILDBIRTH, SEXUALITY – IN STRIPES AND TRIANGLES, the time is part when women dared not portray their fears, hatred, experience of oppression – we are no longer afraid to show in images the violence of our anger and remorse, and also our great sadness and love.

True life and inspiration know no false limits and prejudice as to technical means.

Almost every male artist in the past was a member of the elite. Their leisure was bought at the cost of mothers, daughters, sisters, wives – who were allowed to be workers, models, supporters, secretaries, drudges but NEVER allowed themselves to create. (as well as reaping the wealth created by the working class and third world peoples)

We, the ones, who have been subjected to humiliation every day of our lives, denied our identity, history and tradition, are not the ones to stand back coolly and analytically take of objectivity and abstraction. So-called objectivity – what is but the separation of thought and reason from our real desires and wishes? Men use the terms to hide they have desires and wishes. Women are expected to follow suit and deny their own. FUCK YOUR "OBJECTIVITY" AND YOUR MIDDLE-CLASS CULTURE.

We want to give expression to the REAL hopes needs and beliefs of women – of people – struggling to escape from oppression both material and psychological – servitude and contempt.

Even our history must be rewritten. Are we to continue bearing the myth that women are, have been, and will be passive, uncreative, and mentally inferior? The split between body-soul, material-spirit is a false separation of patriarchal civilizations who have formulated theories and philosophies over thousands of years excusing and re-inforcing our oppression by saying that women represent the negative, the dark, the passive, the non-creative and non-spiritual aspect and matter that men have to surpass and exploit in order to become pure spirit, pure activity, pure artist, aggressive – and defined by men – positive energy.

LIES AND LIES ARE WE BRED ON! We are slaves with the consciousness of slaves.

But myths are not destroyed solely by social change and logic.

Women painters wish to destroy the myth of inferiority and replace it with a new pride and joy in womanhood – in sisterhood – and of all aspects of life that have been deformed and brutalized by capitalism and the patriarchal atomized family. We also want to release men from their narrow pseudo-scientific dogmatism, the need to assert and subjugate in order to feel strong (some men cannot get a 'hard-on' unless they degrade and humiliate a woman sexually and mentally). Womankind, like the surface of this earth, has been ravaged because of this false need.

But now WE ARE RISING to re-recreate at last our strength, dignity, wisdom, and creativity of woman of the ancient past. WE WISH TO ACHIEVE A WORLD VIEW.

In ancient cultures life and art were integrated. Art was the great religious rituals – the initiation dramas that expressed the collective dreams and experience of the whole community concerning life and the universe. Music, dance, masks, carvings, murals, all served a purpose and together they created a wholeness. But…art which had once been the expression of both sexes became later divided into the Sacred and the Profane. Sacred art became a male province in the hands of a male priesthood, when the priestesses of the Great Mother were deposed at the beginning of the patriarchal era, and women were left with the 'lesser arts' of pottery, weaving, etc.

Our dreams, hopes, feelings, cannot be realized in present patriarchal, capitalistic society that denies all experience or expression that does not serve the exploitation of aspirations, feelings, intuition and experience of women. WOMEN LIVE A SHADOW LIFE.

There is a one-sex view of art today; what we always see is the men's vision of himself, the world, and women. We are sick, sick, sick of the continual visual exploitation of women's bodies, of women as objects. 'I paint with my prick' said Renoir – only too true……

But we are women and WE ARE SUBJECTS and will portray ourselves as such and so at last we will end the ages of pornography-vision of women. If a woman dares to portay a man as her sexual object there is outcry heard all over the land. [Editor's note – Monica Sjoo did just that and her work was ordered to be taken down by police – in the haven of artists – St. Ives, Cornwall]

We are told we are not in the mainstream of artistic exploration, that we are not exploring modern forms; that we are 'out on a limb' – but we tell you that IT IS YOU WHO ARE ON A LIMB!

What you have now is a half-word imagery at the point of stagnation. Women are presently accepted into the art world only if they confirm to the acceptable attitude of the already dominant male art view of what art is and was; again HIS vision. Male artists have explored every aspect of the half world view and expression, they express frustration in thrusting big, bigger, and biggest objects and canvasses, all with no content whatsoever and with no relation to real human feelings or aspirations. They have reached a dead end.

But for women our explorations start now – we do not identify creative energy with phallic thrusting aggressiveness. Perhaps women have in fact great artistic traditions in the ancient past. Who created the cave paintings? If one knows that the cave was a womb and the sanctuary of the Great Mountain Mother, who was served by female priests and who was the mother of all animals, once can well ask if the murals were not the work of women. Pottery was invited by women and the forms and patterns of ancient pottery are some of the greatest treasures of the past. The palaces of Crete with their beautiful murals and central heating systems – were not they the work of women painters and architects? In Africa women are musicians and dancers, they have secret songs and dances. Why so little is known about female cultures is because the majority of anthropologists have been men and these women's initiations and secret societies are not open to men observers. In folk music in England a great many of the recorded folksongs were taken down from women singers. In America there was a whole tradition of blues singers like Bessie Smith and Ma Rainey. So little is know about women's art because male historians have little interest in

recording what women have created and achieved. It has been a positive embarrassment to them but human life is an inter-action between two sexes. Art must be the expression of the total human world and only art fed by female and male views inter-acting can be vital. The time is NOW and it is overdue!

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Reprinted from *n.paradoxa: international feminist art journal* vol. 28 (July 2011) pp.64-67.
This manifesto was written when the group WOMANPOWER formed in 1971 and was first published in *Towards a Revolutionary Feminist Art* (Bristol, 1972). Monica Sjöö published several editions of this publication in 1971-1972 as a low-cost stapled magazine and in 1974 as *Some Thoughts on Feminist Art*. The group included Liz Moore, Beverley Skinner, Anne Berg, Rosalyn Smythe and Monica Sjöö. They exhibited together in *WOMANPOWER: 5 Women Artists* at Swiss Cottage Library, London in April 1973.

A MANIFESTO FOR THE FEMINIST ARTIST (1972)

RITA MAE BROWN

Art in the past has been the pursuit of the privileged with few exceptions, it has been white, male, usually middle to upper class, and overwhelmingly heterosexual. All forms of the arts — music, dance, literature, painting, film, etc. — reflect the concerns of this dominant group with a few male homosexuals thrown in for good measure. Only recently have the concerns of other people and their art begun to emerge, especially within the Black community, and in its beginning stages among women.

Today 90% of what is available to the public remains the art of the oppressor. Since they control the business end of the arts they control what is presented to people. Therefore precious little of our work leaks out to the mass public. But their arts for all its dominance is in such decline it has reached the final stages of disease and decadence. That art offers us two poles: nostalgia and porno-violence. Both come from emptiness, starvation of creativity and hope, and incredible self-indulgence.

Their concept of self has become so perverted that older members of the oppressor generation seek the coordination of their fragmented selves on a graph of the past, nostalgia. Meanwhile the younger generation gives itself in an orgy of porno-violence. The male ego is so eroded that these younger men — the inheritors of the political-economic reins of the death culture — seek an affirmation of self in violent, destructive sex. Porno-violence is their symbol of protest that in its essence denies not only dignity and equality to women but even life to women. Rape is the cliché of male art be it individual rape or the systematic brutalization of an entire sex and entire races.

As women artists we are in deep revolt against this rotting art just as we are in revolt against the syphilitic political structures that damage us and endanger world peace.

Our experiences have been locked away from the eyes and ears of the people. We must fight to transmit those experiences forcing people to face the reality of our lives, of all oppressed people's lives. But our art must be more than personal narrative; it must contain a vision for the future where no group rapes another, where force is not the heart of politics and egotism not the mind of art.

Our task is to achieve a synthesis of poetry and politics, theater and experience, love and society. We have to pull together a world compartmentalized by the resident schizophrenics in the White House, the Pentagon and General Motors. We have to build an alternate media, a new art to help us create a new government in which all people are free. Let our work be the bridge to that new world.

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First published in *The Furies, Lesbian/Feminist Monthly* Vol. 1, issue 5 (June-July 1972). This journal is archived online at http://www.lesbianpoetryarchive.org/node/131

WOMEN'S ART: A MANIFESTO (1972)

VALIE EXPORT

THE POSITION OF ART IN THE WOMEN'S LIBERATION MOVEMENT
IS THE POSITION OF WOMAN IN THE ART'S MOVEMENT.

THE HISTORY OF WOMAN IS THE HISTORY OF MAN

because man has defined the image of woman for both man and woman, men create and control the social and communication media such as science and art, word and image, fashion and architecture, social transportation and division of labor. men have projected their image of woman onto these new media, and in accordance with these medial patterns they gave shape to woman. if reality is a social construction and men its engineers, we are dealing with a male reality. women have not yet come to themselves, because they have not had a chance to speak insofar as they had no access to the media.

let women speak so that they can find themselves, this is what I ask for in order to achieve a self-defined image of ourselves and thus a different view of the social function of women. we women must participate in the construction of reality via the building stones of media-communication.

this will not happen spontaneously or without resistance, therefore we must fight! if we shall carry through our goals such as social equal rights, self-determination, a new female consciousness, we must try to express them within the whole realm of life. this fight will bring about far reaching consequences and changes in the whole range of life not only for ourselves but for men, children, family, church... in short for the state.

women must make use of all media as a means of social struggle and social progress in order to free culture of male values, in the same fashion she will do this is in the arts knowing that men for thousands of years were able to express herein their ideas of eroticism, sex, beauty including their mythology of vigor, energy and austerity in sculpture, paintings, novels, films, drama, drawings etc., and thereby influencing our consciousness. it will be time.

AND IT IS THE RIGHT TIME

that women use art as a means of expression so as to influence the consciousness of all of us, let our ideas flow into the social construction of reality to create a human reality. so far the arts have been created to a large extent solely by men. they dealt with the subjects of life, with the problems of emotional life adding only their own accounts, answers and solutions. now we must make our own assertions. we must destroy all these notions of love, faith, family, motherhood, companionship, which were not created by us and thus replace them with new ones in accordance with our sensibility, with our wishes.

to change the arts that man forced upon us means to destroy the features of woman created by man, the new values that we add to the arts will bring about new values for women in the course of the civilizing

process. the arts can be of importance to the women's liberation insofar as we derive significance — our significance — from it: this spark can ignite the process of our self-determination, the question, what women can give to the arts and what the arts can give to the women, can be answered as follows: the transference of the specific situation of woman to the artistic context sets up signs and signals which provide new artistic expressions and messages on one hand, and change retrospectively the situation of women on the other.

the arts can be understood as a medium for our self-definition adding new values to the arts. these values, transmitted via the cultural sign-process, will alter reality towards an accommodation of female needs.

THE FUTURE OF WOMEN WILL BE THE HISTORY OF WOMAN.

This manifesto was written in March 1972, first published in *Neues Forum* 228 (Jan 1973) p. 47. Translated from German to English by Regina Haslinger. It was distributed on the occasion of the exhibition *Magna Feminismus: Kunst und Kreativitat* (Wien/ Vienna, Galerie Nachst St Stephan, 1976), curated by EXPORT. It was republished in Kristine Stiles and Peter Selz (eds.) *Theories and Documents of Contemporary Art, A Sourcebook of Artists' Writings* (University of California Press, 1996) and in Helena Reckitt (ed.) *Art and Feminism* (London: Phaidon, 2001).
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WOMANIFESTO (1975)

CRAFTED and ADOPTED by 80 WOMEN at
CONFERENCE of FEMINIST FILM and VIDEO ORGANIZATIONS, NEW YORK, 2 FEBRUARY 1975

As feminists working collectively in film and video we see our media as an ongoing process both in terms of the way it is made and the way it is distributed and shown. We are committed to feminist control of the entire process. We do not accept the existing power structure and we are committed to changing it, by the content and structure of our images and by the ways we relate to each other in our work and with our audience. Making and showing our work is an ongoing cyclical process, and we are responsible for changing and developing our approaches as we learn from this experience.

We see ourselves as part of the larger movement of women dedicated to changing society by struggling against oppression as it manifests itself in sexism, heterosexism, racism, classism, ageism, and imperialism. Questioning and deepening our understanding of these works and of how language itself can be oppressive is part of our ongoing struggle. We want to affirm and share the positive aspects of our experience as women in celebration.

First published in *Media Report to Women* (1975), republished in *Women & Film* 2 No 7: 11 (1975) and in Scott MacKenzie (ed.) *Film Manifestos and Global Cinema Cultures: A Critical Anthology* (University of California Press, 2014). Cited in full in Martha Allen 'The Development of Communication Networks Among Women, 1963-1983: a history of women's media in the US' (Women's Institute for Freedom of the Press, 1988)

Reproduced with kind permission of Ariel Dougherty, an organizer of the original conference in 1975. Other organizers were Carol Clement, Phyllis Gomperts and Ann Volkes. Barbara Halpern Martineau (aka Sara Halprin) wielded the pen during the collective drafting of the WOMANIFESTO. Laurel Siebert co-ordinated the conference effort.

MANIFESTO FOR A RADICAL FEMININITY FOR AN OTHER CINEMA (1977)

MARIA KLONARIS and KATERINA THOMADAKI

> "It is within the female sex that orgasm remains the most enigmatic, the most inaccessible; its ultimate essence has probably not yet been authentically located."[1]

1. ON A FEMININE CULTURE: OBVIOUS FACTS

The existing culture is a male domineering culture, created by man for his own image/benefit.

Woman contributed to its creation, but mostly as a support for the male 'spirit'. In this culture, woman is near-absent. Unknown. Ignored. Mute. Imprisoned. Despised. Deformed. Enigmatic. Inaccessible.

In this culture, femininity is but a male projection.

The feminine culture remains to be created.

It is already being created by women unsubmissive to male order.

Through this culture alone, woman will be able to conquer the political territories necessary to her empowerment.

All woman's creative acts highlighting the distance between a general, standardised, male fabricated femininity and a self-revealed specific and unique female identity contribute to the creation of this culture.

> "This said, I increasingly think that we should refrain from gendering cultural productions: this would be 'feminine', this would be 'masculine'. The issue seems different to me: it is about giving women the economic and libidinal conditions which will allow them to analyse and deconstruct social oppression and sexual repression, so that every woman may express and develop her own singularities and her own differences, as they have been produced by the risks and necessities of nature, family or society."[2]

A feminine culture can only be rupture from dominant culture.

Can only be the negation of dominant language.

Can only reject the processes of dominant art.

Can only let arise all that is oppressed by social order: body, desire, sexuality, unconscious, singularities.

Can only let the rebellion of the repressed fracture the norms of expression.

2. VISION OF A RADICAL FEMININITY

A radical femininity can only break, shatter, crush, tear apart all that weighs on her and restrains her.

Can only invent and explode.

Ripping her inventions from the depths of her own guts. Giving birth to her own identity.

A radical femininity can only be a harmony between so called feminine and masculine traits.

A symbiosis of “female” and “male” energies.

Can only be an equilibrium between the physical sex and the mental, subjective sex.

Can only bring together contradictory and/yet complementary pulsions.

A radical femininity can only be a whole – neither fragment nor lack nor deficiency.

A yoghini manifesting a serpentine energy out of her vulva.

3. PASSION FOR A RADICAL CREATION: THIS OTHER CINEMA

Unsubmissiveness. Independence. Rupture. Autonomy.

To tear apart the economic dependence of the cinema of huge crowds, huge budgets, huge means, huge consumption, huge dependency.

To tear apart the illustrative images, hostages of the social tales merchandised by the capitalist film industry.

To shatter the academicism of the gaze maintained by the industry of images.

To shatter the prefabricated notions of “real”, “natural”, “normal”, “objective”, “comprehensible” – alibis of a society which can only produce neuroses propagated by mass media.

To shatter the partition of specialisations.

To shatter hierarchies and roles.

To shatter the mirror of the fabricated woman, the passive actress, the one who obeys, the one who accepts being manipulated, the one who mediates for a stranger's orgasm. To shatter glasses and mirrors.

I emerge.

A radical femininity can only blossom within a radical creation.

I construct my own images.

I invent my own vision, neither "natural" nor 'normal' nor 'objective', but real as it surges from desire, and comprehensible if one forgets whatever institutions have taught us to understand.

I free my own introspection.

I expose my roots and my sufferings: childhood, desire, revolt, repression, torture, old age, death.

I expose my archetypal and social colours: red, black, white, pink, gold, silver.

I stage my own mental structures, my geometries.

My body image imprints the film.

I open myself to you by my sentient and sensitive body. My body of woman-subject.

I offer you the rituals of my identity.

A haemorrhage of identity not mediated by anyone else, but fully asserted by myself in front of you.

I look at you.

I question you.

I give birth to an OTHER cinema.

Copyright © Maria Klonaris/Katerina Thomadaki, Octobre 1977. All rights reserved.
First published in *CinémAction I, Dix ans après mai 68, Aspects du cinéma de contestation* (Paris, 1978).
The original version of this manifesto is in French on Maria Klonaris/Katerina Thomadaki's website.

Translated by Cécile Chich, with thanks to Katerina Thomadaki.

Notes

1. Jacques Lacan “L’angoisse” Cité par Irène Diamantis in “Recherches sur la féminité”, *Ornicar? Analytica*, vol. 5.
2. Julia Kristeva “Unes femmes” propos recueillis par Eliane Boucquey *Les Cahiers du GRIF* n° 7 (Juin 1975).

WOMEN IN THE YEAR 2000 (1977)

CAROLEE SCHNEEMANN

By the year 2000 no young woman artist will meet the determined resistance and constant undermining that I endured as a student. Her Studio and Istory courses will usually be taught by women. She will never feel like a provisional guest at the banquet of life; or a monster defying her "God-given" role; or a belligerent whose devotion to creativity could only exist at the expense of a man, or men and their needs. Nor will she go into the "art world", graving or disgracing a pervading stud club of artists, historians, teachers, museum directors, magazine editors, gallery dealers – all male, or committed to masculine preserves. All that is marvelously, already falling around our feet.

She will study Art Istory courses enriched by the inclusion, discovery, and reevaluation of works by women artist; works (and lives) until recently buried away, willfully destroyed, ignored, or reattributed (to make artists with whom they were associated). Our future student will be in touch with a continuous feminine creative istory – often produced against impossible odds – from her present, to the Renaissance, and beyond. In the year 2000, books and courses will be called "Man and His Image," "Man and His Symbols," "Art History of Man" only to probe the source of dis-ease and man-ia which compelled patriarchal man to attribute to himself and his masculine forebearers every invention and artifact by which civilization was formed for over four millennia!

Our woman will have courses and books on "The Invention of Art by Woman," "Woman –The Source of Creation," "The Gynocratic Origins of Art," "Woman and Her Material." Her studies of ancient Greece and Egypt will reconcile manipulations in translation, interpretation, and actual content of language and symbolic imagery with the protracted and agonizing struggle between the integral, cosmic principles of Gynocracy and the aggressive man-centered cultures gathered as the foundations of Judeo-Christian religion in the Western world.

Fifteen years ago I told my Art Istory professor I thought the base breasted women bull jumpers, carved in ivory, painted in frescos about 1600 B.C. in Crete, could have been made by women depicting women. and I considered that the preponderant neolithic fertility figurines might have been crafted by women for themselves – to accompany them through preganancy and birth-giving. And I wondered if the frescos of the Mysteries, Pompeii – almost exclusively concerned with feminine gestures and actions – could have been painted by women. He was shocked and annoyed, saying that there was absolutely no authority to support such ideas. Since then I have given myself the authority to support and pursue these insights. By the year 2000 feminist archeologists, etymologists, egyptologists, biologists, sociologists, will have established beyond question my contention that women determined the forms of the sacred and the functional – the divine properties of material, its religious and practical formations; that she evolved pottery, sculpture, fresco, architecture, astronomy and the laws of agriculture – all of which belonged implicitly to the female realms of transformation and production.

The shadowy notions of a harmonious core of civilisation under the aegis of the Great Mother Goddess,

where the divine unity of female biological *and* imaginative creation was normal and pervasive, where the female was the source of all living and created images will once again move to clarify our own conscious desires. The sacred rituals of forming materials to embody life energies will return to the female source

One further change will be the assembling of pioneer istorians – themselves discredited or forgotten by traditional masculist authority. In the year 2000 they will be on the required reading lists! what a joy to welcome: Helen Diner, J.J. Bachofen, Michelet, Rilke, Gould-Davis, Jane Ellen Harrison, Robert Graves, Jacquetta Hawkes, Ruth Benedict, Robert Briffault, Erich Neumann, H.D., Marie de LeCourt, Ruth Herschberger, Bryher, H.R.Hays, Mina Mosdherosch Schmidt, Clara E.C.Waters, Elizabeth F. Ellet!

The negative aspect is simply that the young woman coming to these vital studies will never really beleive that we in our desperate ground work were so crippled and isolated that a belief and dedication to a feminine istory of art was designed by those who might have taught it, and considered heretical and false by those who should have taught it. That our deepest energies were nurtured in secret, with precedents we kept secret – our lost women. Now found and to be found again.

From Carolee Schneemann *More than Meat Joy. Complete Performance Works and Selected writings* (ed.) Bruce McPherson (New Paltz, New York: Documentext, 1979) pp.198-199. Also reproduced in Kristine Stiles and Peter Selz (eds.) *Theories and Documents of Contemporary Art, A Sourcebook of Artists' Writings* (University of California Press, 1996) and in Carolee Schneemann *Carolee Schneemann: Imaging her Erotics: Essays, Interviews, Projects* (MIT, 2002).
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FIRST MANIFESTO ON THE CULTURAL REVOLUTION OF WOMEN (1978)

ZSE BUDAPEST
ULRIKE ROSENBACH
SUSAN B. ANTHONY COVEN

the witch-mothers

feminist witch-mothers are women who seek the feminine principle within themselves and feel conjoined with the triple creatress as daughters.

religion and politics are interdependent.

we believe that at a time when we are fighting for the right to control our own bodies, it is also time to fight for the well-being of our souls.

we believe that in addition to the fight for our rights, which will last for generations, we must also find a way to continually replenish our positive energies. we believe that without a secure foundation in the spiritual realm, there can be no progress for us.

we believe that we are part of a changing universal consciousness that was predetermined thousands of years ago in the age of the matriarchies.

we believe that the renewed development of feminine creativity and power will engender new strength for a humane development of our society.

we commit ourselves to living our lives in love of ourselves and our sisters.

we are conjoined with joy, self-love and self-assertion.

we commit ourselves to vindicating our interests and those of our sisters by learning the magic arts: through blessing, through punishing, through healing, and through the inclusion of what is insufficiently rooted in our community identified by women.

women’s magic is not only a religion. it is a way of living. in the cults of the mother, the magic of women was general knowledge. it was information about how women can live freely on this planet.

rediscovering this capability is one of the important contributions that women of the feminist movement have to give.

we must learn how we can trust our soul by learning that our right to own it is rooted in

our consciousness of the goddess, the feminine principle of the universe, and in ourselves.

this is the source of our independence.

we are prepared to battle those who are simplistic.

we are equal and committed to contributing to political, communal and personal solutions.

we are committed to teaching women how they can organise themselves as witch-mothers and will share our traditions with them.

we deny men the teaching of our magic.

our immediate goal is to assemble with one another according to our old laws of women and to remember our past, to renew our power, and to affirm our goddess of the ten-thousand names.

Translated from German by Aileen Derieg.
Reprinted with kind permission of Ulrike Rosenbach.
This manifesto was written while Ulrike Rosenbach was running Schule fur Kreativen Feminismus in Cologne, Germany.
See Ulrike Rosenbach 'Schule fur Kreativen Feminismus in Köln (1976-1982)' vol. 26 *n.paradoxa: international feminist art journal* (July 2010) pp.66-69.

CHANGE, MY PROBLEM IS A PROBLEM OF A WOMAN (1979)

EWA PARTUM

A woman lives in a social structure that is alien to her. Its model, superannuated in relation to her current role, was created by and for men. A woman can operate in a social structure that is alien to her if she masters the discipline of camouflage and leaves out her own personality. At the moment of discovering her own awareness, possibly having little in common with the realities of her current life, a social and cultural problem arises. Not fitting into the social structure created for her, she will create a new one. This possibility of discovering the self and the authenticity of her own experiences, work on her own problems and awareness through the very specific experience of being a woman in a patriarchal society in a world that is alien to the self, is the problem of what is called ‘feminist art’. It is the motivation for creating art for a woman artist. The phenomenon of feminist art reveals to a woman her new role, the possibility of self-realisation.

Copyright © Ewa Partum, Warsaw 1979.

The performance/action, *Change, My Problem is a Problem of a Woman*, took place in Galeria Art Forum (Lodz) in 1979. In the performance, the artist also talked to the public about cosmetic surgery, about woman as sexual object in patriarchal culture, and about socially conditioned stereotypical images of both men and women. She also presented texts on feminism in art by Lucy Lippard and Valie Export as recordings played on a tape recorder. The performance was recorded on film. This event was a different restaging of her 1974 performance of the same name where Partum had half of her face "aged" by professional make-up artists.

WOMEN ARTISTS OF PAKISTAN MANIFESTO (1983)

SIGNED BY 15 WOMEN ARTISTS IN LAHORE

We, the women artists of Pakistan,

having noted with concern the decline in the status and conditions of life of Pakistani women; and

having noted the adverse effects of the anti-reason, anti-arts environment on the quality of life in our homeland; and

having noted the significant contribution the pioneering women artists have made to the cause of arts and art education in Pakistan and

believing as we do in the basic rights of all men, women and children to a life free from want and enriched by the joys of fruitful labour and cultural self-realisation; and our commitment, as practitioners and teachers of the arts, to the noblest ideals of a free, rational and civilised existence:

affirm the following principles to guide us in our struggle for the cultural development of our people to serve as the manifesto of the women artists of Pakistan

1. We acknowledge the outstanding contribution made by women artists to the conservation and promotion of the artistic genius of our people and their role in pioneering art education in the country; we salute them for this and for their determination to spread out at all levels of education and to all strata of society.

2. We unreservedly support the Pakistani women's struggle for equality of rights, status, and dignity with menfolk.

3. We call upon women engaged in any creative field in Pakistan to stand together for the cause of women's emancipation not only from all constraints, perpetrated in the name of law and morality, but also from all forms of prejudice, superstition and cant.

4. We recognise, respect and uphold the right of every woman artist to her own faith, her individual approach to content, form, medium, method, technique and style in the realisation of her artistic ideals. And we denounce any attempt, overt or covert, to suppress, inhibit, control or regiment her artistic functioning, or to interfere otherwise, with her basic right to freedom of expression.

5. We vigorously condemn the attitude which minimises woman's constructive role in society, and attempts to restrict her active and rightful participation in society.

6. We condemn the attitude which distorts the original and age-old role of woman as the fiver and sustainer of life, love and affection and vulgarises it into an image of obscenity.

7. We call upon all women artists to take their place in the vanguard of the Pakistani women's struggle to retain their pristine image and their rightful place in society.

So that we may replace in the lives of our people despair with hope, brutality with compassion, darkness with light, and anarchy with culture, and leave the world a happier, more beautiful and more peaceful a place than we found it.

****

Signed by 15 Women Artists in Lahore - 1983

Rabia Zuberi
Abbasi Abidi
Mamoona Bashir
Salima Hashmi
Lala Rukh
Talat Ahmad
Zubeda Javed
Sheherezade Alam
Jalees Nagi
Birjees Iqbal
Riffat Alvi
Meher Afroz
Nahid
Qudsia Nisar
Veeda Ahmed

Reproduced in Salima Hashmi *Unveiling the Visible: Lives and Works of Women Artists of Pakistan* (Pakistan: Sang-e-Meel Publications, 2002).
Courtesy of Salima Hashmi.

THERE HAVE ALWAYS BEEN GREAT BLACKWOMEN ARTISTS (1986)

CHILA KUMARI BURMAN

We face many problems when trying to establish the very existence of Blackwomen's art, and a strong social and political base from which to develop our study of it. Firstly, we have to struggle to establish our existence, let alone our credibility as autonomous beings, in the art world. Secondly, we can only retain that credibility and survive as artists if we become fully conscious of ourselves, lest we are demoralised or weakened by the social, economic, and political constraints which the white-male art establishment imposes and will continue to impose on us.

This paper, then, is saying Blackwomen artists are here, we exist and we exist positively, despite the racial, sexual and class oppressions which we suffer, but first, however, we must point out the way in which these oppressions have operated in a wider context – not just in the art worlds, but also in the struggles for black and female liberation.

It is true to say that although Blackwomen have been the staunchest allies of black men and white women in the struggle against the oppression we all face at the hands of the capitalist and patriarchal system, we have hardly ever received either the support we need or recognition of our pivotal role in this struggle. Blackwomen now realise that because of the specific ways in which we are oppressed by white-male dominated society, we must present a new challenge to imperialism, racism and sexism from inside and outside the established black liberation movement. It is this realisation which has a lot to do with many second generation British Blackwomen reclaiming art, firstly as a legitimate area of activity for Blackwomen as a distinct group of people, secondly as a way of developing awareness (denied us by the racist, sexist, class society) of ourselves as complete human beings, and thirdly as a contribution to the black struggle in general.

Having said this, Blackwomen's ability to do any or all of these three things is restricted by the same pressures of racism, sexism and class exclusivity which we experience in society in general, The bourgeois art establishment only acknowledges white men as truly creative and innovative artists, whilst recognising art by white women only as a homogenous expression of femininity and art by black people (or, more accurately, within the terms of reference used, black men as a static expression of the ritual experience of the daily lives of their communities, be they in the Third World or the imperialist hinterland. In this system of knowledge, Blackwomen artists, quite simply, do not exist.

Nevertheless, if we look at the way in which these assumptions have been challenged to date, particularly by white women, we can see nothing that acknowledges that Blackwomen exist. Art history is an academic subject, studied in patriarchal art institutions, and white middle-class women have used their advantageous class position to gain access to these institutions by applying pressure to them in a way which actually furthers the exclusion of black artists in general. White women's failure to inform

themselves of the obstacles faced by black artists and in particular Blackwomen artists has lead to the production of an extremely Eurocentric theory and practice of 'women's art'. It seems that white feminists, as much as white women in general, either do not attempt or find it difficult to conceive of Blackwomen's experience. Some of those who do not attempt to may claim that they cannot speak for Blackwomem, but this is merely a convenient way of sidestepping their own racism. The fact remains that in a patriarchal and sexist society, all black people suffer from racism, and it is quite possible for white women to turn racism, which stems from patriarchy, to their advantage. Black men are unable to do this and, theoretically, are unable to turn sexism to their advantages, although they can do this for short-term gains which in the long term will never benefit black people as a whole. This has happened to a certain extent in the art world, where black men have failed to recognise Blackwomen artists or have put pressure on us to produce certain kinds of work linked to a male-dominated notion of struggle. However, because of their race and class position, black men have been unable to use the resources of information in art institutions in the same way white middle-class women have.

The struggles of Blackwomen artists

The first stage of most Blackwomen artists' encounter with the art establishment is their entry into art college. There are hardly any Blackwomen attending art college in Britain, and those who do, according to a survey of Blackwomen artists I carried out, seem to have experienced a mixture of hostility and indifference from their college. Because their white tutors work within an imperial art tradition, using the aesthetic conventions of the dominant ideology, they are unwilling to come to terms with Blackwomen students and their work. This resistance manifests itself in many ways – some Blackwomen art students have found themselves asking why they as individuals found it easy to get into art college, only to realise that they are there purely as tokens, and in general it appears that Blackwomen's very presence in white-male art institutions is frequently called into question. Apart from denying us the support and encouragement that white art students receive, art colleges make us feel as though we don't belong inside their walls by the way in which our work is looked at. Those of us who have done more overtly political work have made white tutors very uncomfortable and, as a result, hostile, whilst students who have done less obviously challenging work have been questioned for not producing the kind of work which tutors expect black people to produce. Class differences amongst Blackwomen are significant here, for working-class Blackwomen have generally been quicker to reject the ideology of the art establishment and have therefore found it difficult to accept any kind of token status or to produce work of a more acceptable nature. Those who have not taken such an oppositional stance have still suffered from having their work analysed within a very narrow framework because their tutors have expected them to produce 'ethnic' work which reflects their 'cultural origin' using, for example, 'bright carnival colours', and white tutors and students alike have expressed confusion when such work has not been forthcoming. Another tendency of white tutors, irrespective of the work they are presented with, is to discuss art from the third world with Blackwomen in a patronising and racist manner.

Of course, the assumption that Blackwomen will produce work with 'ethnic' or 'primitive' associations is one that white tutors make about black men as well, but it is important to point out that male and female white tutors are more inclined to see black men as having a more prominent role in this misconceived tradition. One Blackwoman student at Bradford art college commented:

'Funny how they always refer to you as some sort of bridge or crossing point between two things. Black meets woman. That's handy. As if you don't have an experience which is your own, but borrow

from the brothers and sisters in struggle.'

It seems, then, that when art colleges and universities give places to Blackwomen, which in itself is a rare event, all the forces of the dominant aesthetic ideology are brought to bear on us. Blackwomen artists are ignored, isolated, described as 'difficult', slotted into this or that stereotype and generally discouraged in every conceivable way from expressing ourselves in the way we want to. This system of oppression and exclusion extends well beyond our time as art students. There are no full-time lecturing posts at art colleges and universities filled by Blackwomen in the entire country - instead we are offered 'freelance' work as visiting lecturers, which will never be enough to initiate a critique of contemporary art practice which is so desperately needed in every single art department in the country.

In addition, Blackwomen artists are denied the opportunity to develop their work as individuals to develop their work as individuals in the same way that white artists can through grants from sources such as the Arts Council, the Greater London Council, regional arts associations and the Calouste Gulbenkian Foundation. Even through some of these sources such as the GLC and the Greater London Arts Association have recently begun to realise how much they have neglected Black visual arts, on the only occasion that a Blackwoman had received funding from the GLC as an individual, this has still been on unsatisfactory terms which differ significantly from the terms on which the only black man in this position has been funded. The man in question has been funded without any preconditions except that he produces a certain amount of work, whilst, the woman was funded by the Arts and Recreation Department of the GLC for a year on the condition that she was attached to a community arts centre has a 'community artist', and the stipulation was made that work she produced should not reflect her desires as an individual but the interests of the 'black community' of the experience of an individual Blackwomen and had funded her on the basis of an historical notion of 'community' or 'ethnic minority' art, but when it came to applying for the Arts Council, it appeared that the role she has been pushed into was not individual enough . The rejection of her application to this body read:

'We do not think that your proposed project fits the terms of reference for this training scheme which is specifically aimed at developing the individual's skills, and is not to assist with research projects.'

If even the GLC funded a Blackwoman artist only as a 'community artist', this illustrates our position in a kind of funding no-woman's-land, because the Arts Council, racist and sexist as it is already, will continue to see our work as unfundable research projects and, as was the case with the application mentioned, refer us to bodies such as the Association of the Commonwealth Universities, further relegating us to the marginality of the 'ghetto artist', completely outside the mainstream British art world.

Blackwomen artists fight back

The resilience of Blackwomen in the face of oppression has manifested itself in the art world through our ability to produce and exhibit work despite all the social, economic and political constraints described above. The first all-Blackwomen's show at the Africa Centre in 1983 was not just a beginning; Blackwomen artists have been actively involved in exhibitions with white artists and Black men artists for several years, but this all-Blackwomen's show and the ones that have taken place since then – Blackwoman Time Now, 1985 International Women's Day Show, Mirror Reflecting Darkly, etc.- represent a significant new direction which has much to do with the development of what Barbara Smith describes as 'our own intellectual traditions'.

It is obvious that the majority of Black artists see their work in opposition to the establishment view of art as something that is 'above' politics, and Blackwomen artists see their work as integral to the struggles of Blackwomen and black people in general, but although Blackwomen's own culture plays a large part in determining the culture and form of our work, we often concentrate on different issues to black men, who, as one Blackwoman artist points out, often believe that 'artists who are making through their works a collective, aggressive challenge to cultural domination are "real" black artists and making Black Art. But some male artists fail to go through to assert their identity and survive'.

Alice Walker illustrates the difference between these two ideas of Black Art in 'In Search for Our Mothers' Gardens' and goes on to put forward an alternative way for the black artist to operate:

"I am impressed by people who claim they can see everything and event in strict terms of black and white but their work is not, in my long contemplated and earnestly considered opinion, either black or white, but a dull, uniform gray. It is boring because it is easy and requires only that the reader be a lazy reader and a prejudiced one. Each story or poem has a formula usually two-thirds 'hate whitey's guts' and one third 'I am black, beautiful and almost always right'. Art is not flattery, and the work of every artist must be more difficult than that.

'My major advice to young black artists would be that they shut themselves up somewhere away from all the debates about who they are and what colour they are and just turn out paintings and poems and stories and novels. Of course the kind of artist we are required to be cannot do this (our people are waiting)'.

Alice Walker's advice is important here, for she is not suggesting that we cut ourselves off from the outside world, because we cannot forget the mark our oppression as black women have made on us, or the fact that 'our people are waiting'. The point is that what we need as artists is the opportunity to create the situation she describes so that we are allowed to develop an understanding of ourselves and of the struggle we have to wage within British society for recognition and respect. If we are able to do this by having adequate resources put at our disposal, we hope to share our experiences with, awaken the consciousness of and impart our strength to the whole society.

This is a synopsis of a talk by Chila Burman delivered at the Black Visual Artists Forum, ICA, London, 25-26 October 1986.
It was first published in *Women Artists Slide Library Journal* No. 15 (February 1987) pp.9-11, then reprinted in Hilary Robinson (ed.) *Visibly Female* (London: Camden Press, 1987).
Copyright © Chila Burman.
See also: Rina Arya *Chila Kumari Burman: Shakti, Sexuality and Bindi Girls* (KT press, 2012).

THE MANIFESTO: EVA AND CO. (c. 1992)

EVA AND CO.

Eva and Co. has chosen to take her own life!

1. Eva and Co. has sinned. Against our better judgement, we have kept up too long with our non-conformist market attempts. Ten years Eva and Co – women´s artist´s group and feminist cultural magazine are enough! (or too much?)

2. Eva and Co. takes the first step; other institutions could follow us! Many of them are overdue and continue to exist only because they are too cowardly to draw the obvious conclusions from their paradoxical and unproductive work. Women are braver!

3. We no longer secretly ask ourselves: for what?

4. The magazine Eva and Co. was expensive and elitist. We did not manage to make a mass circulation magazine out of it. Consumption is everything – as digestible and entertaining as possible, open to everyone, not too demanding and please, not too serious!

5. Eva and Co. served as the token presence of women in the art world. We are no longer the token! It is everyone´s responsibility that women appear more in the public domain.

6. Besides: art is not wanted! You make yourself an enemy of the people. Official support barely keeps us alive. But one gets the impression that the officials themselves don´t know exactly why, and that they are only too cowardly to cut off the supply of money.

7. An enemy of the state as decoration? Art as a piece of jewelry for politicians, fashionable urban citizens and image conscious companies. Art as enticement for streams of tourists. Graz as cultural city.

8. The content of art, the subversive, the revolutionary, the questioning is silenced. Instead, formalities, cliches like “freedom of expression”, the art market, etc. are discussed.

9. We know about our so-called artistic freedom to do as we please, but we no longer want to be the fools. We are serious about content.

10. Today everything is valued through money. What we are doing obviously has no value – we draw the conclusions. Art is valuable only as an object of speculative

investment

11. We reject art! Women, stop producing art, it is pointless! Remember: women´s art is not in! The racism proliferating everywhere demands its victims. We are not the first!

12. We refuse to continue creating art! Parties are cheaper and you can use something else for decoration

13. Success killed us. And not only us – but we won´t allow it to bureaucratize us, to burn us out or to pacify us!

14. Art should be a laboratory. The importance of an experimental stage has to be recognized and promoted. It is necessary for every innovation and indispensable for surviving.

15. We demand diversity of art and not official decisions about what art is.

16. Art is political and socially relevant

17. Women artists are supposed to be perfect housewives, organizers, managers, gallery owners, etc. Enough! In the future, men will be allowed to organize; we will focus on our art.

18. It is not sufficient to organize women artists in associations. We will develop better strategies and form ourselves anew! We will infiltrate everything! We will go underground and to the sky. And be warned: in the future we will camouflage ourselves.

19. From now on we will again give free rein to our madness.

20. Women artists will be as present everywhere as in Eva and Co.

21. Thus we demand: Only women´s art for the next ten years!

31. 12. 1992
Eva and Co.
We were: Eva Ursprung, Veronika Dreier, Erika Thümmel, Reni Hofmüller.

Copyright © Eva Ursprung.
With Veronika Dreier, Dorothea Konrad, Silvia Ulrich, Anne Wrulich.
Translation by Anna Wagner, Kristin Conradi.

First published in 1992 when the feminist group, Eva and Co., disbanded. Eva and Co. had for 10 years produced a journal, organised exhibitions and projects in Austria and elsewhere and were also a rock band.
Reproduced with permission of the authors from http://www.grassrootsfeminism.net/cms/node/243
Veronika Dreier and Eva Ursprung, with Doris Jauk-Hinz, later formed W.A.S. (Womyn's Art Support).

See Judith Schwentner 'Kunstverein W.A.S. (Womyn's Art Support) the danube streaming show, Veronika Dreier, Doris Jauk-Hinz, Eva Ursprung in the conversation with Judith Schwentner' *n.paradoxa: international feminist art journal* vol. 17 (Jan 2006) pp.60-69.

BITCH MUTANT MANIFESTO (1994)

VNS MATRIX

The atomic wind catches your wings and you are propelled backwards into the future, an entity time travelling through the late C20th, a space case, an alien angel maybe, looking down the deep throat of a million catastrophes.

> screenflash of a millionmillion conscious machines
> burns brilliant
> users caught in the static blitz of carrier fire
> unseeing the download that scribbles on their burntout retinas
> seize in postreal epileptic bliss
> eat code and die

Sucked in, down through a vortex of banality. You have just missed the twentieth century. You are on the brink of the millenium - which one - what does it matter? It's the cross dissolve that's captivating. The hot contagion of millenia fever fuses retro with futro, catapulting bodies with organs into technotopia . . . where code dictates pleasure and satisfies desire.

> Pretty pretty applets adorn my throat. I am strings of binary. I am pure artifice. Read only my memories. Upload me into your pornographic imagination. Write me. Identity explodes in multiple morphings and infiltrates the system at root.

Unnameable parts of no whole short circuit the code recognition programs flipping surveillance agents into hyperdrive which spew out millions of bits of corrupt data as they seize in fits of schizophrenic panic and trip on terror. So what's the new millenium got to offer the dirty modemless masses? Ubiquitous fresh water? Simulation has its limits. Are the artists of oppressed nations on a parallel agenda? Perhaps it is just natural selection?

The net's the parthenogenetic bitch-mutant feral child of big daddy mainframe. She's out of of control, kevin, she's the sociopathic emergent system. Lock up your children, gaffer tape the cunt's mouth and shove a rat up her arse.

We're [con]verging on the insane and the vandals are swarming. Extend my phenotype, baby, give me some of that hot black javamagic you're always bragging about. (I straddle my modem). The extropians were wrong, there's some things you can't transcend.

> The pleasure's in the dematerialisation. The devolution of desire.

We are the malignant accident which fell into your system while you were sleeping. And when you wake we will terminate your digital delusions, hijacking your impeccable software.

Your fingers probe my neural network. The tingling sensation in the tips of your fingers are my synapses responding to your touch. It's not chemistry, it's electric. Stop fingering me.

Don't ever stop fingering my suppurating holes, extending my boundary but in cipherspace there are no bounds [or so they say]
BUT IN SPIRALSPACE THERE IS NO THEY

there is only *us*
Trying to flee the binary I enter the chromozone which is not one
XXYXXYXXYXXYXXYXXYXXYXXYXXYXXYXXYXXYXXYXX genderfuck me baby
resistance is futile
entice me splice me map my ABANDONED genome as your project artificially involve me
i wanna live forever
upload me in yr shiny shiny PVC future

SUCK MY CODE

Subject X says transcendence lies at the limit of worlds, where now and now, here and elsewhere, text and membrane impact. Where truth evaporates Where nothing is certain There are no maps. The limit is NO CARRIER, the sudden shock of no contact, reaching out to touch [someone] but the skin is cold...

The limit is permission denied, vision doubled, and flesh necrotic.

Command line error

Heavy eyelids fold over my pupils, like curtains of lead. Hot ice kisses my synapses with an (ec)static rush. My system is nervous, neurons screaming - spiralling towards the singularity. Floating in ether, my body implodes.

I become the FIRE.

Flame me if you dare.

Copyright © VNS MATRIX,1994.

This text was widely circulated on the net. This version is reproduced from *n.paradoxa online* Issue 4 (August 1997) pp.6-8.
VNS Matrix was an artist collective founded in Adelaide, Australia in 1991, by Josephine Starrs, Julianne Pierce, Francesca da Rimini and Virginia Barratt. Along with Sadie Plant, the group are credited with the invention of the term "cyberfeminism". One of their earliest projects was *Cyberfeminist Manifesto for the 21st century* (1991), a poster/image/statement smuggled into various websites, placed in the printed advertisements of magazines and posted in public spaces, as well as broadcast over the radio and on television and online in various remix and broadcast forms. The text of this poster is available here or here.
See Verena Kuni 'Die Flanerin im Datennetz. Wege und Fragen zum Cyberfeminismus' in Sigrid Schade-Tholen/Georg Christoph Tholen (eds.) *Konfigurationen. Zwischen Kunst und Medien* (Munich, 1999) pp. 467–485 and Louise Mayhew 'VNS Matrix: A case study of women-only collectivism and collaboration in Australia' from her PhD 'Female art collectives and collaborations in Australia c.1970-2010' (University

of New South Wales).

CONSTITUTION INTEMPESTIVE DE LA RÉPUBLIQUE INTERNATIONALE DES ARTISTES FEMMES (1995)

VIOLETTA LIAGATCHEV

Article l - Avoir la conscience la plus planétaire possible du monde.
Vivre avec le paradoxe de ses différences.
Créer sa propre vision du monde et la communiquer à travers ses oeuvres.

To have the most global consciousness of the world.
To live with the paradox of one's differences.
To create one's own worldview and communicate it through one's works.

Article 2 - Ne pas se laisser intimider par la frustration des mères.

Do not let yourself be intimidated by the frustration of mothers.

Article 3 - Ne pas se faire souffrir par tradition

Do not make yourself suffer by tradition.

Article 4 - Ne pas se représenter comme un objet

Do not represent yourself as an object.

Article 5 -Tirer le profit des cultures qui nous ont précédées et ne pas respecter les les barbaries. Nous pouvons juger l'histoire

To take advantage of preceding cultures and not respect barbarisms. We can judge history.

Article 6 - Ne pas s'abstraire du monde. La rivalité des femmes est le principe de leur soumission

Do not withdraw from the world. Rivalry between women is the [basic] principle of their submission.

Article 7 - Ne pas rester à la traîne des monopoles culturels. Les devancer en étant sensibles aux changements discrets du monde.

Do not lag behind cultural monopolies. Get ahead [of them] by being aware of the discreet changes of the world.

Article 8 - Créer un langage sincère et direct.

To create a direct and genuine language.

Article 9 - Ne pas se sous-estimer, ne pas sur-estimer, sachant qu'on a la liberté de tout faire.

Do not undervalue yourself, do not overvalue, knowing that you are free to do anything.

Article 10 - Ne pas cautionner par l'art, ni par le silence, la démagogie de la guerre, de la violence, du principe premier, de la sclérose culturelle des habitués du pouvoir

Do not give excuse to nor support through art or silence the demagogy of war, of violence, of the first principle, of the cultural sclerosis of powermongers.

Article 11 - Réactiver la vie de l'art

To reactivate art life.

JE ME SUIS RETROUVÉE DANS UN CIEL DE MATERIALITÉ. CHAUD, DOUX. ET AUX MILLIERS D'ÉTOILES. CHAQU'UNE DE CES ÉTOILES PEND LÉGÈREMENT EN DESSOUS DU FIRMAMENT.

I FOUND MYSELF IN A SKY OF MATERIALITY. WARM, SOFT. AND WITH THOUSANDS OF STARS. EACH ONE OF THESE STARS SLIGHTLY HANGING BENEATH FIRMAMENT.

L'UNIVERS EST FINI CAR RIEN NE LE DÉPASSE LE MONDE EST ROND ETMONDE - ON LUI A ATTRIBUE D'ÊTRE FEMME. EST rond et c'est juste une extérieure ressemblance. C'est comme si on n'arrivait pas à distinguer un chien d'un autre chien.

THE UNIVERSE IS FINITE AS NOTHING GOES BEYOND IT THE WORLD IS ROUND AND WORLD – IT HAS BEEN SAID TO BE WOMAN. IS round and this is but an external resemblance. As if it was not possible to distinguish one dog from another dog.

MAIS MOI FEMME JE VOIS ET JE JUGE. JE GOUTTE ET JE RESSENS.

BUT I WOMAN [I] SEE AND [I] JUDGE. I TASTE AND I FEEL.

CE QUI EST FIN JE VEUX LE PARTAGER. LA BRUTALITÉ. QU'ELLE LEUR SOIT LA MASTURBATION.

WHAT IS [THE] END I WANT TO SHARE. BRUTALITY. MAY IT BE MASTURBATION TO THEM.

JE PEUX MOI FEMME , T'AIMER, TE CHÉRIR. ET TE DONNER MON ADORATION ABSOLUE.

MAIS À CONDITION QUE TOI HOMME TU ABANDONNES A JAMAIS L'USAGE DES ARMES. TA VIOLENCE. ET TA FOLIE MEURTRIÉRE QUI TE POUSSE VERS LE POUVOIR. SINON TU N'ES RIEN. ET TU PÉRIRAS TOUT SEUL SOUS LE POIDS DE TA SAUVAGERIE.

I, WOMAN, CAN LOVE YOU, CHERISH YOU. AND GIVE YOU MY ABSOLUTE ADORATION. BUT ONLY IF YOU MAN FOREVER GIVE UP THE USE OF WEAPONS. YOUR VIOLENCE. AND THE DEADLY MADNESS THAT DRIVES YOU TO POWER. OTHERWISE YOU ARE NOTHING. AND YOU WILL PERISH ALONE UNDER THE WEIGHT OF YOUR OWN SAVAGERY.

CAR MOI FEMME . JE NE SUIS PLUS D'ACCORD DE SOIGNER TES BLESSURES DE GUERRE, NI DE TE PARDONNER QUOI QUE CE SOIT.

BECAUSE I WOMAN DO NO LONGER AGREE TO CARE FOR YOUR WAR WOUNDS, NOR TO FORGIVE YOU ANYTHING.

Violetta Liagatchev is an artist. Her ‘Untimely Constitution of the International Republic of Female Artists’ was published as her contribution to *Masculin-Feminin* (George Pompidou Centre, Paris, 1995-1996). She was born in 1966 in Moscow and has French nationality. She studied at the National Upper School of Fine Art, Paris (1986-1991); Rijksakademie (1992); MA, Marseilles (1993-1994). She has shown her videos, photography, paintings, drawings and artists books in numerous exhibitions in France, Japan and Russia.

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Reproduced from n.paradoxa online Issue 3 (May 1997) pp.44-46.

Translated from French by Cécile Chich.

100 ANTI-THESES (1997)

OLD BOYS NETWORK

1. cyberfeminism is not a fragrance
2. cyberfeminism is not a fashion statement
3. sajbrfeminizm nije usamljen
4. cyberfeminism is not ideology
5. cyberfeminism nije aseksualan
6. cyberfeminism is not boring
7. cyberfeminism ist kein gruenes haekeldeckchen
8. cyberfeminism ist kein leerer kuehlschrank
9. cyberfeminism ist keine theorie
10. cyberfeminism ist keine praxis
11. cyberfeminism ist keine traditio
12. cyberfeminism is not an institution
13. cyberfeminism is not using words without any knowledge of numbers
14. cyberfeminism is not complete
15. cyberfeminism is not error 101
16. cyberfeminism ist kein fehler
17. cyberfeminism ist keine kunst
18. cyberfeminism is not an ism
19. cyberfeminism is not anti-male
20. sajbrfeminizm nige nesto sto znam da je
21. cyberfeminism is not a structure

22. cyberfeminismo no es uns frontera
23. cyberfeminism nije poslusan
24. cyberfeminism nije apolitican
25. cyberfeminisme is niet concreet
26. cyberfeminism is not separatism
27. cyberfeminism is not a tradition
28. cyberfeminism is not maternalistic
29. cyberfeminisme id niet iets buitenlands
30. cyberfeminism is not without connectivity
31. cyberfeminismus ist nicht mehr wegzudenken
32. cyberfeminismus ist kein oxymoron
33. cyberfeminism is not on sale
34. cyberfeminism is nor for sale
35. cyberfeminismus ist nicht gut
36. cyberfeminismus ist nicht schlecht
37. cyberfeminismus ist nicht modern
38. cyberfeminismus ist nicht post-modern
39. cyberfeminism is not natural
40. cyberfeminism is not essentialist
41. cyberfeminism is not abject
42. cyberfeminism is not an avatar
43. cyberfeminism is not an alter ego
44. cyberfeminismus ist nicht truegerisch
45. cyberfeminismus ist nicht billig
46. cyberfeminismus ist nicht willig

47. cyberfeminisme n'est pas jaloux
48. cyberfeminism is not exclusive
49. cyberfeminism is not solid
50. cyberfeminism is not genetic
51. cyberfeminismus ist keine entschuldigung
52. cyberfeminism is not prosthetic
53. cyberfeminismo no tiene cojones
54. cyberfeminisme n'est pas triste
55. cyberfeminisme n'est pas une pipe
56. cyberfeminism is not a motherboard
57. cyberfeminism is not a fake
58. cyberfeminism nije ogranicen
59. cyberfeminism nije nekonfliktan
60. cyberfeminism nije make up
61. cyberfeminism nije zatvoren prozor
62. cyberfeminism is not a lack
63. cyberfeminism is not a wound
64. cyberfeminism is not a trauma
65. cyberfeminismo no es una banana
66. cyberfeminism is not a sure shot
67. cyberfeminism is not an easy mark
68. cyberfeminism is not a single woman
69. cyberfeminism is not romantic
70. cyberfeminism is not post-modern
71. cyberfeminism is not a media-hoax

72. cyberfeminism is not neutral
73. cyberfeminism is not lacanian
74. cyberfeminism is not nettime
75. cyberfeminism is not a picnic
76. cyberfeminism is not a coldfish
77. cyberfeminism is not a cyberepilation
78. cyberfeminism is not a horror movie
79. cyberfeminism is not science fiction
80. cyberfeminism is not artificial intelligence
81. cyberfeminism is not an empty space
82. cyberfeminism is not immobile
83. cyberfeminism is not about boring toys for boring boys
84. cyberfeminismus ist keine verlegenheitsloesung
85. cyberfeminism is not a one-way street
86. cyberfeminism is not supporting quantum mechanics
87. cyberfeminism is not caffeine-free
88. cyberfeminism is not a non-smoking area
89. cyberfeminism is not daltonistic
90. cyberfeminism is not nice
91. cyberfeminismo no es callado
92. cyberfeminism is not lady.like
93. cyberfeminismus ist nicht arrogant
94. cyberfeminismus ist keine nudelsauce
95. cyberfeminism is not mythical
96. cyberfeminism is not from outer space

97. cyberfeminismo no es rock 'n roll

98. cyberfeminism is not dogmatic

99. cyberfeminism is not stable

100. cyberfeminism has not only one language

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The Old Boys Network was founded in Berlin in Spring 1997 by Susanne Ackers, Julianne Pierce, Valentina Djordjevic, Ellen Nonnenmacher and Cornelia Sollfrank.
This text was produced from the first Cyberfeminist International in 1997, a 10-day workshop with 36 international participants held at Hybrid Workspace, *documenta 10*, Kassel. The group's members, publications and activities are documented on their website.

LILIES OF THE VALLEY UNITE! OR NOT (1998)

LILY BEA MOOR

Me Being
Me
Being

is not
an
Action Verb

While
others of my sort
Bang about
Creating Monuments

of

Steel/Marble
Gran ite
This is what the Craft's
All About

Working Hard
with Pleasure
Pounding things out

is is

a Pleasurable
Pursuit

Working Hard
As I
Hardly work
I Relish

in Creating Art
Wherever my I
My Lazy Eye
Finds It

My colleagues
Work Hard
to Bring their
Plans to Fruition
Giant Canvases Packed with Colour-Rooms Filled with Stuff
Strategically
Placed

The(n) am I the Queen Bea
Content to have my Grapes Peeled
or not
Content to Watch the
Workers scurry about

I Take a pointer
touch and object
and say
“There
I proclaim you art”
As a Queen
Wood say to a Night

Problem is no
Body Recognizes
This Process
“OF” ART
There is no
Stamina involved
Thinking time
is Mini-mal
Hands-on
Barely

Considering
Proliferators
DaVinci, Picasso, Rivera, Georgia O'K,…the guy who did
Mt.Rushmore, Puryear, Noguchi, Ann Hamilton, Kahlo, Mr.
Imagination, Hammons and the Like

LILIES OF THE VALLEY UNITE!

I THINK NOT!!!

Lilies of the Valley

DON'T DO A DAMN THING
Yet our Presents
is FELT
like an Anarchist

BECAUSE
We do in deed
E X I S T

Written in Fall 1998, under her pseudonym Lily Bea Moor, this previously unpublished poem by artist and author Senga Nengudi was first reproduced in the exhibition catalogue *Double Consciousness: Black Conceptual Art Since 1970* (USA: Contemporary Arts Museum Houston, 2005), curated by Valerie Cassel Oliver.
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100 IMPOSSIBLE ARTWORKS (2001)

DORA GARCIA

1. To live the life of another

2. To dream the dreams of another

3. Not to die

4. To be, even if only for one second, with each and every human being

5. To write down all their names

6. To be in several places at once

7. To decide one's own dreams

8. To recite all the stories of the world

9. To control someone else, entirely

10. To resurrect, even if only partially

11. To die several times

12. To live several lives

13. To be aware of all flights, their departure points and their arrival points

14. To occupy the physical space of another body

15. To share hallucinations

16. To live again one's own childhood

17. To suppress one colour from human perception

18. To introduce a new colour in human perception

19. To find your own doppelgänger and live with him together

20. To travel in time

21. To move backwards and try to get younger this way

22. To exclusively hear the sounds produced by one's own body

23. To be alone, literally alone in the world

24. To invert the sexes

25. To repeat again and again the same scene, while the audience gets old and dies

26. To limit the number of questions and answers

27. To fly, or move very fast

28. To know the truth

29. To live forever underground

30. To know exactly how many times someone has cried

31. To finish someone's unfinished oeuvre

32. To fake all feelings

33. To forget everything

34. To remember everything

35. To confer life to the lifeless

36. To speed time at will

37. To prophesy

38. To read minds

39. To eliminate some past events

40. To hinder some future events

41. To multiply the light of the sun

42. To store one's breath

43. To synchronize all clocks

44. To be loved by every one

45. To fill up an abyss

46. To substitute all books for their image in the mirror

47. To attend the end of the world

48. To cancel one day

49. To make all books contain the same text

50. To change the name of a big city

51. To change the names of all its inhabitants

52. To sweat gold

53. To create automatons able to think

54. To see everything

55. To attend the beginning of the world

56. To touch time

57. To wear away a human body by touching it

58. To see consecutive events as simultaneous

59. To see one's own face

60. To be the only one who can see in the planet of the blind

61. To exist in another dimension

62. To quit sleeping

63. To sleep forever

64. To live together with a ghost

65. To feel someone else's pain

66. To have one's feelings totally under control

67. To see the human soul

68. To synchronize all breathings

69. To undo an irreversible decision

70. To ignore death

71. To be identical to another

72. To listen to all conversations

73. To be behind and before the door

74. To suppress the eyelids' flutter

75. To suppress memories at will

76. To be motionless

77. To stop decay

78. To be transparent

80. To change night for day

81. To invert hierarchies

82. To change the meaning of words

83. To traverse walls

84. To reincarnate several times and very fast

85. To remember the body positions adopted while sleeping

86. To create invisible, but blocked barriers

87. To extend the limits of the human body

88. To alter the obedience of mirrors

89. To rewind one's life

90. To live on the other side

91. To be insane or sane at will

92. To change sex and age at will

93. To see through someone else's eyes

94. To live under hypnoses

95. To compose the soundtrack of someone's life

96. To convince someone that she is actually dead

97. To dream again last night's dreams

98. To fall endlessly

99. To photograph every moment of our life

100. Nothing

Dora García *100 Impossible Artworks* (2001) is a text piece by the artist which has been presented in different formats: as a wall text, as flyers, posters and t-shirts (MUSAC Collection, León).
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REFUGIA: MANIFESTO FOR BECOMING AUTONOMOUS ZONES (BAZ)(2002)

SUBROSA

REFUGIA: “A place of relatively unaltered climate that is inhabited by plants and animals during a period of continental climate change (as a glaciation) and remains as a center of relict forms from which a new dispersion and speciation may take place after climatic readjustment.” (Webster’s New Collegiate Dictionary, 1976)

REFUGIA: Sections of agricultural fields planted with non-transgenic crops, alternating with transgenic crops. This is thought to limit the rate of resistance mutation caused in susceptible insect and weed species by gene transfer from GE mono-culture crops.

REFUGIA: A Becoming Autonomous Zone (BAZ) of desirous mixings and recombinations; splicing female sexual liberation and autonomy with cyberfeminist skills, theory, embodiment, and political activism.

REFUGIA: A critical space of liberated social becoming and intellectual life; a space liberated from capitalist Taylorized production; a space of unregulated, unmanaged time for creative exchange and play; experimental action and learning; desiring production, cooking, eating, and skill sharing.

REFUGIA: A reproducible concept that can be adapted to various climates, economies, and geographical regions worldwide. Any useless space can be claimed as a refugium: suburban lawns, vacant urban lots, rooftops, the edges of agricultural lands, clear-cut zones in forests, appropriated sections of mono-culture fields; fallow land, weed lots, transitional land, battle-fields, office-buildings, squats, etc. Also currently existing Refugia such as multi-cultivar rice paddies, companion planted fields, organic farms, home vegetable gardens, etc.

REFUGIA: A post-modern commons; a resistant biotech victory garden; a space of convivial tinkering; a commonwealth in which common law rules. Not a retreat, but a space resistant to mono-culture in all its social, environmental, libidinal, political, and genetic forms.

REFUGIA: A habitat for new AMOs (Autonomously Modified Organism) and agit-crops; for example, “ProActiva,” an herb that is a grafting of witch-root, mandrake, and all-heal.

REFUGIA: A place of asylum for the recuperation, regeneration and revitalization of useless GE crops that have been corrupted by capitalist viruses and agribusiness greed.

REFUGIA: A place of imaginative inertia that slows down the engines of corporate agro/biotech and allows time to assess its risks and benefits through long-term testing.

REFUGIA: Neither a utopia nor a dystopia, but a haunted space for reverse engineering, monstrous graftings, spontaneous generation, recombination, difference, poly-versity hybridization, wildlings, mutations, mongrelizing, crop circles, anomalies, useless beauty, coalitions, agit-crops, and unseemly sproutings. Biotech and transgenic work in Refugia will be based on desire, consensual public risk assessment, informed amateur experimentation, contestational politics, nourishment and taste value, non-proprietary expertise, convivial delight, and healing.

REFUGIA: subRosa's on-going cyberfeminist hothouse of strategies and tactical actions.

subRosa is a feminist art collective.
Current members are Faith Wilding and Hyla Willis.
Courtesy of subRosa.
First published in Maria Fernandez, Faith Wilding, Michelle M. Wright (eds.) *Domain Errors: Cyberfeminist Practices!* (New York: Autonomedia, 2002).

CARNAL ART MANIFESTO/L'ART CHARNEL (2002)

ORLAN

Definition: Carnal Art/L'Art Charnel is a work of self-portraiture in the traditional sense, but using technological means that are those of its time. It oscillates between disfigurement and refigurement. It is inscribed in the flesh because our epoch has started to make that possible. The body becomes a **"modified ready-made"**, for it is no longer the ideal readymade that only has to be signed.

Distinctness: Unlike **"Body Art"** from which it differs, Carnal Art does not wish for pain, does not seek it as a source of purification, does not conceive of it as Redemption. Carnal Art is not interested in the final plastic result, but in the surgical-intervention-performance and in the altered body, which has become a place of public debate.

Atheism: To put it plainly, Carnal Art is not the heir of the Christian tradition: it fights against it! It highlights Christianity's negation of the "body as pleasure" and uncovers areas where Christianity collapses in the face of scientific discovery. Nor is Carnal Art the heir of a hagiography interspersed with beheadings and other martyrdoms; it adds rather than taking away, heightens the faculties instead of reducing them. Carnal Art does not set out to be self-mutilating. Carnal Art transforms the body into a language and overturns the Christian principle of the word become flesh in favour the flesh become word; only Orlan's voice will remain unchanged, the artist works on representation.

Carnal Art considers the famous **'in pain you shall bring forth children'** anachronistic and ridiculous. Like Artaud it wants to have done with the judgement of God; now we have epidurals and many kinds of anaesthetics and analgesics. Long live morphine! Down with pain!

Perception: I can now see my own body open without suffering at the sight … I can see myself down to myinnermost entrails, a new stage of the mirror. **'I can see my lover's heart, and its splendid design has nothing to do with the symbolic vapidities that are usually drawn.'**

Darling, I love your spleen, I love your liver, I adore your pancreas and the line of your femur arouses me.

Freedom: Carnal Art asserts the artist's individual freedom, and in that sense it also fights against prejudices and dictats; that is why it is inscribed in the social sphere, in the media (where it causes scandal because it upsets accepted ideas) and will go as far as the legal sphere.

Clarification: Carnal Art is not against aesthetic surgery, but it is opposed to the standards it conveys which are inscribed in women's flesh in particular, but also in men's. Carnal Art is feminist, that is essential. Carnal Art is interested in aesthetic surgery, but also in the leading-edge techniques of medicine and biology which raise questions about the status of the body and pose ethical problems.

Style: Carnal Art loves the baroque and parody, the grotesque and styles that are rejected, for Carnal Art is opposed to the social pressures that are exerted both on the human body and on the corpus of works of art.

Carnal Art is anti-formalist and anti-conformist.

The Carnal Manifesto is reproduced from *Orlan: Elément Favoris: Exposition Rétrospective* (Carquefou, France: Frac des Pays de la Loire, 27 Nov. 2002-26 Feb. 2003).

It was translated from French by Judith Hayward when it was republished in *n.paradoxa: international feminist art journal* vol.12 (July 2003) pp.44-48.

Copyright © Orlan, courtesy of artist.

THE SCUB MANIFESTO (2002)

RHANI LEE REMEDES

SCUB

the Society for Cutting Up Boxes.

S. Society: a group of people

C. Cutting: to slice away notions and boundaries

U. Up: to be positive

B. Boxes: the thing in which restricts our thoughts and actions based on the square, cardboard and rigid structure that groups and sub-groups use to sufficate and close in persons' identities and/or non-identities

SCUB

SCUB is all for...

1. IMPROVING THE QUALITY OF LIFE

2. FASHION

3. COMMUNICATION

4. REVOLUTION

5. DESTRUCTION

IMPROVING THE QUALITY OF LIFE: **SCUB** makes people walk down the street with ease and inspiration. In being liberated by **SCUB**, colors will look brighter, music will sound clearer and your dancing will be greater. More beer on the streets. "Children" will be able to frolick amongst their peers. When asked, "What do you want to be when you grow up?" they respond, "Me."

FASHION: Boring fashion will be shutdown and re-opened with whatever YOU want.

COMMUNICATION: What happens when two boxes try to talk? Nothing,right? Time to cut up the boxes, NOW.

REVOLUTION: skill building with knives, scissors, razors, box-cutters, electric knives,

saws of all sizes, teeth, long sharp nails, keys, shards of glass, cheese cutters and so on...

DESTRUCTION: why put up with identities when you can destroy them? Just to let you know, SCUB does not support the destruction of "animals" and their wood tree environments. Destroy.

BOX ME IN?

NO THANKYOU.

Copyright © Rhani Lee Remedes.
First published in LTTR (2002). Ginger Brooks Takahashi, K8 Hardy and Emily Roysdon founded LTTR in 2001 and this was part of their inaugural issue in September 2002 titled 'Lesbians to the Rescue'. SCUB refers back to Valerie Solanas' *SCUM Manifesto*, popularly known as the 'Society for Cutting Up Men'.

MANIFESTO OF FACTORY OF FOUND CLOTHES (2002)

FACTORY OF FOUND CLOTHES

The place of the artist is on the side of the weak.

Weakness makes a person human, and it is by overcoming weakness that heroes are born.

We do not extol weakness, but rather appeal to kindheartedness and humanity.

The time has come to return compassion to art!

Compassion is an understanding of the weakness of others and a joint victory over that weakness.

You cannot call it sentimentality.

It is Freedom standing on the barricade with naked breast, defending the child in each of us!

You say that art is only for the very smart, that it's an intellectual game? That there is no place left for true impact, that strong emotions belong exclusively to Hollywood? It's not true! Because in that case, art would be meaningless, cold, incapable of extending a helping hand.

Art is not an abstract game but an adventure; not cold rationalism, but live emotion. The artist is not a mentor or tutor, but a friend; not a genius, but an accomplice. Rather than enacting didactic social projects, we must help people to stop fearing themselves, help them to accept themselves and grow better. Society is made up of people. Only by helping these people follow the path of self transformation, do we change society. There is no other way.

Copyright © FFC.
The Factory of Found Clothes (FFC or Fabrika Nadyonii Odezhdii in Russian, FNO) is Natalya Pershina-Yakimanskaya and Olga Egorova, respectively known as Gluklya and Tsaplya. FFC was founded in 1995 in St Petersburg and has produced works in installation, performance, video, text and 'social research' which develop an operational logic of 'fragility' as subjectivity antagonistic to that which is the state of things – be that the repressive social and political climate of Russia or the reflexive futilities of international art scenes.

FEMINIST ART ACTION BRIGADE - MANIFESTO (2003)

FEMINIST ART ACTION BRIGADE (FAAB) !

We would like to announce the inauguration of FAAB, the newest feminist art organization in Tokyo.

"Feminism? Isn't it dead?"
Well, no. In the past decade or two, we thought modernism is dead, history is dead, etc., but old habits die hard. While we thought ideologies were dead, Imperialism, colonialism, and militarism all made great comebacks. The bad old patriarchal system is more alive than ever. They have become unapologetically ruthless.
Faced with this harsh reality, we think feminism is still one of the few ideals we can hang on to in order not to be completely disillusioned by the state of the world today. We know there are many different versions of "feminism". Our version of feminism is made clear in the statement below.
We would like to stress that our feminism is not to expand the rights of the "biological female".

"All we need is Action!"
FAAB is not a fraternity club.
We are a brigade of artists who use our artistic expression as weapons. We don't have one "commander", instead, whoever plans a project is responsible for the completion of that project.

Our current projects are:
"ACTION IN SILENCE" exhibition in which documentation of world wide anti-war,anti-imperialism movement will be shown along with performances and installation.
"MINI QUEER SHOW" a preparatory exhibition for a big international queer Show in the future.

Whoever or whatever group which want to do something with us, participate in our events, support FAAB, be on our Mailing list, please get in touch with us.

Ito, Tari
Lim, Desiree
Nishimura, Yumiko
Ono, Nonko
Shimada, Yoshiko
Takahashi, Fumiko
Yasuda, Kazuyo
(in alphabetical order)

FAAB Manifesto

FAAB questions the prevailing social and artistic value system.
What is valuable art and who can be artists?
Rather than making a pyramid shaped value system, can we make a horizontal system in which we all express ourselves equally and freely?
We think feminism is still one of the most useful and practical ideals to make this happen.

What we call feminism here is not a movement for increasing women's equality to men.
What we call feminism is for all, not only for the biological female.
We think that patriarchal system is pretty much responsible for the current awful world of violence and greed, but we are not a negative, "anti-male" movement at all. Rather, we seek for a better, equal system for all.

We will work with minority people, groups, individuals who are striving to make a change in the prevailing mainstream social system.
Our action is not confined in the so-called "cultural" activities.
Culture is closely connected to society, nation, world politics. We are not afraid to be political as well as artistic, at the same time.

FAAB was formed in Tokyo by the women named above and their collaboration lasted for around one year.
This text is taken from their announcement of the group on Nettime, 4 Jun 2003 and online at Japan's Gender and Arts Project website.
Reproduced with kind permission of Yoshiko Shimada.

YES MANIFESTO (2004)

METTE INGVARTSEN

Yes to redefining virtuosity
Yes to “invention” (however impossible)
Yes to conceptualizing experience, affects, sensation
Yes to materiality/ body practice-investment
Yes to expression
Yes to excess
Yes to un-naming, decoding and recoding expression
Yes to non-recognition, non-resemblance
Yes to non-sense/ illogics
Yes to organizing principles rather than fixed logic systems
Yes to moving the “clear concept” behind the actual performance of
Yes to methodology and procedures
Yes to editing and animation
Yes to style as a result of procedure and specificity of a proposal
Yes to multiplicity, difference and co-existence

Copyright © Mette Ingvartsen.
First published in *Fraktija, Performing Arts Journal.*
Reproduced in Astrid Peterle ‘The Performances of Mette Ingvartsen: the pleasures of depersonalized bodies, bouncing trampolines and evaporated landscapes’ n.paradoxa: international feminist art journal vol. 25 (January 2010) p.37.
Mette Ingvartsen ‘YES MANIFESTO’ online [Accessed 25 October 2009].

MANIFESTO ARCO (2005)

XABIER ARAKISTAIN

After three decades, during which feminist assumptions have characterised, with greater or lesser success, the conceptual frameworks of artists and the different specialists that render and/or purge art, we are now beginning to discern a generalised rumour that claims that feminist aims have been attained. Hence, equality-seeking vindications should be démodé, obsolete. But still, the situation of discrimination against women and other marginalised collectives in the social scene in general, and in the art world in particular, remains intact. Consequently, there is a need to develop other kinds of strategies to amend it.

The last two years: the facts

Out of the 28 solo exhibitions scheduled in 2004 at the the Reina Sofía National Art Centre, only four were by women artists. Looking elsewhere, it is truly striking that in the three most recent major exhibitions promoted by different national and local administrations presenting the art of today here in Spain, when viewed in numerical terms, revealed a scandalous exclusion of women artists. The two exhibitions that the Ministry of Foreign Affairs sponsored to represent Spain at the 2003 Venice Biennale did not include a single woman. Gaur, Hemen, Orain, an exhibition held in 2002 at the Bilbao Museum of Fine Arts, which aimed to present the new Basque art scene, featured 20 artists, but only five of these were women. At Manifesta 5, the European Contemporary Art Biennial, whose latest edition was developed in San Sebastian, Spain, and which aimed to give an insight into the most interesting art rendered over the past two years, women artists did not represent more than 20% of the total. The exception that proved the rule was The Real Royal Trip, an exhibition sponsored by Spain's Ministry of Foreign Affairs to promote current Spanish art abroad for New York's MOMA 2 and PS1, which included 40% of women artists. However, this figure contrasts with that of the schedule applied since 2002 by the SEACEX (State Corporation for Cultural Action Abroad), an agency of the Foreign Ministry: of 43 solo shows, only two were by women artists.

We therefore conclude that:

In the Spanish State, art is mainly rendered and administered with public finance, despite which, women's participation in national and international events and scheduled events defrayed with public finance, continues to be anecdotal.

Against this situation of extreme neglect as regards women artists in the worlds of art, Public Administrations are developing a variety of equal opportunity policies for men and women alike in areas such as employment, politics, etc. These general policies, recommendations, and so on, are on the agendas of national governments and international organisations such as the European Union and the United Nations, and often include the use of gender quotas as a regulating mechanism.

Concerned about this blindness regarding gender inequality, the EU has been calling for its member

States to incorporate transversal gender positioning in all of their policies since the 1990s. However, the art scene has remained aloof to these social policies — as if it were not itself part of the social order.

Due to all the above, we propose the following to the Public Administrations:

1.- That an expert group be set up that will study, analyse and diagnose the current situation.

2.- That as many measures as may be required be adopted in order that women artists may work within an impartial context. In the first place, that they should be involved in the purchase policies of the public Museums and in the scheduling of exhibitions.

3.- That the application of firm feminist policies in the field of art be included in the setting up of quotas.

To the art market,

we would like to recall the motto of the Guerilla Girls: 'Dear art collector: how much will your collection be worth when sexism is no longer fashionable?'

SIGNED BY:

Xabier Arakistain. Independent art curator. Spain
Amelia Valcárcel. Vicechair of the Royal Patronage of the Prado Museum; Professor of Moral and Political Philosophy at the University of Oviedo, Spain.
Lourdes Méndez. Professor of Art Anthropology, Euskalherriko Unibertsitatea, San Sebastián, Spain.
Frida Kahlo. Writer and founding member of Guerrilla Girls, New York, USA.
Linda Nochlin. Lila Acheson Wallace, Professor of Modern Art at New York University's Institute of Fine Arts. New York. USA.
María Ruido. Artist, Madrid, Spain.
Ute Meta Bauer. Institute for Cultural Studies at the Academy of Fine Arts Vienna, Austria.
Françoise Duroux. Professor of Philosophy, Lecturer at the University of Paris VIII, France.
Patricia Mayayo. Lecturer, European University of Madrid, Madrid, Spain.
Carmen Navarrete. Lecturer, Polytechnic University of Valencia; artist, Valencia, Spain.
Annika Strömberg. DG Culture, European Union, Brussels, Belgium.

This manifesto was produced at the III International Forum of Contemporary Art Experts, ARCO' 05.
Cycle 8: Equal opportunity policies in the worlds of art.
Madrid 11th February 2005.

THE ROUND TABLES: 'Equal opportunity policies for men and women in the worlds of art: Designing strategies' were organised by Xabier Arakistain, independent curator. Reproduced courtesy of Xabier Arakistain.

JÄMLIKHETSAVTAL #1
(EQUAL OPPORTUNITIES AGREEMENT #1)(2005)

YES! ASSOCIATION / FÖRENINGEN JA!

JÄMLIKHETSAVTAL #1 (EQUAL OPPORTUNITIES AGREEMENT #1) (2005)

The content of the Agreement

The institution hereby agrees to observe equality regarding gender and ethnicity in exhibition programming, acquisitions and staff recruitment.

Equal practice in relation to gender

According to this agreement, an equal exhibition program in relation to gender means that at least half of the exhibited works should be made by women. The practice would still be seen as equal should more than half of the works be made by women, as female artists have been, and still are, underrepresented at state funded art institutions.

According to this agreement, an equal acquisition policy in relation to gender means that at least half of all acquired works should be made by women. The acquisition budget should be equally divided between the sexes. The institution should aim for the entire collection to reach these standards.

According to this agreement, an equal staff recruitment policy in relation to gender means that at least half of the positions advertised after the agreement has been signed should be filled by women. The institution should have equal distribution of men and women across salary levels as a long term goal.

Equal practice in relation to ethnicity

According to this agreement, an equal practice in relation to ethnicity means that the institution’s selection of authors should reflect the ethnic diversity of society. The institution is responsible to find current information about the ethnic make up of society from Statistics Sweden (Statistiska Centralbyrån) or other trustworthy sources.

According to this agreement, an equal acquisition policy in relation to ethnicity means that the acquisitions of the institution should reflect the ethnic diversity of society in regard to authors of the works. The institution’s acquisition budget should take this under consideration. The institution should constantly aim for its complete collection to reflect the ethnic diversity that currently exists in Sweden.

According to this agreement, an equal staff recruitment policy in relation to ethnicity means that the positions that are advertised after the agreement has been signed should be filled in a way that reflects the ethnic diversity of society at the time. The institutions should have as a long term goal to mirror, across

salary levels, the ethnic make up of society.

Evaluation

The exhibition programming, the acquisitions and the staff recruitment will be evaluated every two years. The first evaluation will take place two years following the date when the institution has signed the agreement. The next evaluation will take place after another two years, and so on. The agreement has no expiry date.

Sanction

If, after evaluation, the institution is found not to be in compliance with this agreement, the institution will have to pay a fine of 10 000 SEK (to be adjusted yearly by percentage in relation to the base amount), for each percentage of deficient distribution in regards to gender or ethnicity within the exhibition programming, acquisitions and recruitment. The fine is payable to the YES! Association/FÖRENINGEN JA!'s fund, which has been established to financially support artists who have been victims of discrimination due to their gender, ethnicity or sexual orientation.

Other

If the terms of this agreement have not been fulfilled and the failure is due to the institution's duties as prescribed by employment legislation, the institution will not be held accountable. The institution is bound to this agreement upon ratification by the institution's representative.

Signatures

YES! Association/FÖRENINGEN JA! and the institution each have a copy of this agreement.

Helsingborg, October 15th 2005

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MJÖLKVIK SJÖGLIMT 1 59039 KISA SWEDEN
REGISTRATION NUMBER: 802428-9863
PLUSGIROT ACCOUNT: 304654-7
WWW.FORENINGENJA.ORG
WWW.YESASSOCIATION.ORG

YES! Association/Föreningen JA! is an art collective, an artwork, an association, an institution, a group of people working to overthrow the ruling system of heteronormative, patriarchal, racist, and capitalist power structures by putting into practice a structural redistribution of access

to financial resources, space and time within the art scene.

YES! Association/Föreningen JA! was founded in 2005 in connection with exhibition *Art Feminism – Strategies and Consequences in Sweden from the 1970s to the Present*. At the exhibition opening, YES! Association/Föreningen JA! performed *Press Conference/ Performance* in which they presented gender-specific statistics for the institutions responsible for the exhibition. Towards the end of the press conference, the institutions were invited to sign YES! Association/Föreningen JA!'s Equal Opportunities Agreement #1. All institutions declined unanimously. Since then, the agreement has been reformulated and renegotiated in relation to different institutions and situations, and now exists in several versions, all aimed at promoting social diversity in the field of art.

The activities of YES! Association/Föreningen JA! deal with rights discourse, utopia, assimilation, radical difference, how and if we can name and use identity categories for the purpose of emancipation without reproducing the prevailing discriminatory power structures yet again.

As a means to work through these issues YES! Association/Föreningen JA! uses fiction, enactments and performance. One of the fundamental concepts is to rehearse and/or set in motion a certain situation, and thereby gain experience and skills that can be applied in a future "real-life" situation. Using fiction as a preparation for the future.

YES! Association/Föreningen JA! is run by its board co-art workers: Malin Arnell 2005-present (founder); Åsa Elzén 2008-present; Johanna Gustavsson 2005-2011 (founder); Line S. Karlström 2005-2009 (founder); Anna Linder 2005-2007 (founder); Fia-Stina Sandlund 2005-2008 (founder).

LETTER TO MARINETTI
TO LIBERATE ONESELF FROM ECSTACY OF CONSUMING AND TO DISCOVER THE FUTURE (2009)

ARAHMAIANI

Dear Marinetti,

To speak about the future with the passion and optimism that you had in your life has currently become nearly impossible to accept and to do. After 100 years of passing time, what you dreamed of as a world of "beautiful speed" has turned into "speed that misleads and brings suffering". Maybe you could not imagine this dark side because then imagination and fantasy had not yet grasped it. Speed has now proceeded without control or direction. It has penetrated space and time which was formerly considered to be sacred and pure by those who wish the mystery of life to continue to birth dreams and hope. It has made the world rush helter-skelter without direction. It is as if life has slipped into a space characterized by darkness. The people of Java used this character as a time signifier, and describe it as the times of madness.

True, the idea of progress has birthed acceleration and machines have also created a world full of "wonders". It is as if distances and time have been shortened. It is as if everything is moving fast and efficiently, which at a glance appears to be progressive and so wonderful. The world appears to have shrunk, it has become small — there are no more mysterious places that cannot be reached and discovered. It is as if everything in life and in the universe can now be conquered and controlled. The human being has become the being who sits on the pinnacle of the hierarchy and is permitted to decide where life might be taken and directed to. The shroud of mystery seems to have been completely opened and every answer to every question seems to have been found. But in reality, is it really that way? Does life only offer a limited dimension, merely revealing a handsome face and not revealing another, terrifying face?

The thundering sound of machines which used to signify hope in the future and paradise have now become the thundering sound of anger and destruction. Exploding with shattering sound as murderous machines in the killing fields of the poor and powerless. Or it has become the thundering sound of factory machines that exploit human beings and reduces them to become mere extensions of production means. The machine which you saw as the vehicle that would carry humankind towards enlightenment and a golden age in reality has brought about disasters and tempests. Machines which should help humankind to raise its dignity have now devoured their creators. And wars that depend on various murder machines have now become blatant brutality aimed at multiplying profit.

It seems that those times of promises and dreams have now passed. Science and sophisticated technology has been employed unwisely, they have merely become instruments of power; supports for the fundamental market system. They have failed to answer the challenges of life on planet earth which is

being flailed by violence and poverty. Machines have also thrown up all sorts of poisons and hazardous wastes that have choked life's breathing apparatus, destroyed the natural environment, punctured the ozone layer and strangled humanity, creating wondering zombies. They have become beings without conscience and without feelings, who are always ready to consume anything in their reach. And to do this they will not shrink from murdering and torturing other human beings.

These zombies wear many types of caps and attributes. They can be greedy businessmen or conglomerates who skillfully manipulate consumers who can also bring themselves to burn entire countries to the ground or destroy anything for profit. They can be politicians who hunger for power and who will justify any means to achieve their ambitions. They also have no shame to lick the butts of the conglomerates to receive funds for campaigns and propaganda of the political ideology of whatever-as-long-as-they-have-power. Or they can also appear as intellectuals and religious leaders who pawn and sell their knowledge and their faith in order to be able to lovingly caress power and money.

Power and material things have become potent and intoxicating thirst quenching wines! And under the pressure of the accumulation of material dreams, humanity has gagged its own freedom and its own source of life. The earth is raped, water is wasted and polluted, forests are chopped down and burnt, the soil is poisoned. And everything inside it is consumed and exploited till the end. As if there will be no future coming. The important thing is that today we can swallow and fill our bellies as full as we can and reap as much profit as possible. Time is money and time must be used to seize opportunities to fulfill our needs as soon as right now, because delay means missing opportunities and that means not behaving in accordance to the demands of the times.

The world has now become a village — people can travel from one continent to another in a relatively short time. Places and time have been condensed. Human beings from various social and cultural backgrounds can meet as if differences are no longer an issue. Geographic boundaries have dissolved but mental and psychological gaps have widened and deepened, forming vulgar hierarchical rankings. Life is now divided as such; on one side there is a small group that "possesses special privileges" to obtain anything, in quantities of more than they need. And on the other side there is a large group who "have no rights whatsoever", who are only permitted to dig around in the garbage dumps of the specially privileged group. They also are obliged to offer their time and work to their bones for the welfare of the powerful people above them.

The structure of life has become a two tiered pyramid, where the upper level is lived in by the first group or the rulers who make sure that their standard of life style and civilization must be guaranteed to be special even though they must conduct violence and indulge in criminal ways to maintain that special standard. Meanwhile those who live in the lower level are those who live on the crumbs and leftovers from those upstairs. They also must live in crowded and cramped conditions because their number is great and the space available for them is insufficient. Of course they are also vulnerable to all sorts of bad luck, disease and ill fortune. The term human rights in reality is merely a slogan.

Art and culture

So where is art and culture placed? Part is in the dark lower level of the pyramid and part is used as decoration in the lives of those upstairs, placed in special or private halls that cannot be entered by just anybody! Art becomes objects, things to multiply wealth — art becomes a means of investment that

decorate the sterile walls of auction houses and commercial galleries. Or art is imprisoned in museums to keep company with the ghosts of the past who are drowning in sorrow and shackled by loneliness. Art is alienated from its society and also from its creator — art becomes a mere representation and a spectacle that is to be consumed, it is an image that is porced from life, isolated from reality.

The world that is controlled by the power of capital and often transforms into tyranny has birthed the consumerist and passive life style on a global scale. Humankind has been alienated from itself and also from other human beings. The same has happened in the art world — the artist is swept by the tide of self surrender to the symbolic power that determines the conditions and the classifications of what is termed "art". Art is considered to be "too important" and the artist is ensnared in the trap! So the artist loses her freedom and has reins put on her! Now, art seems to be a burden and a shackle that binds the wings of creativity to prevent them from flying freely!

Obviously this is an extremely absurd situation: art no longer has any connection to life and merely supports the financial market, it is glorified and placed high on a pedestal, it is imprisoned in a place deemed to be secure! Meanwhile, life is slowly being destroyed and humankind is being exterminated through wars and environmental destruction. Indeed, the hard, macho, boots of military soldiers have stomped on our heads and chopped down our conscience to make it bland. Their troops of armored tanks have surged forward to destroy the palace of common sense and are now moving menacingly to completely obliterate the monument of humanity that stands straight before our restless and anxious thoughts.

The bombs that explode in the corners of cities or in the sacred places of Muslims have obliterated the forms of civilizations that were constructed through millennia in a blink of the eye. The sound wakes us up from our slumber and our long dream of eternal life — it has disturbed the Sphinx that has been silent for centuries. It has ripped apart all fantasy and dreams of wisdom, belief, faith, and compassion. It has turned values upside down and created terror upon terror in a never ending life of suffering. It haunts long and exhausting days that are filled with fear and uncertainty. It is as if the pyramid of faith and honesty has also been upturned and now it is spilling tears while it sings a never ending Elegy that has made the Eye swell forever.

The world has shrunk and is on the brink of shattering because of speed! Honestly — now is the time to reduce the speed which you used to think of as the symbol of liberation! Humanity must renew its vision and discover a new human sensitivity and a new human consciousness, to be able to respect the right to live and difference and to erase hierarchy. For the future, for to save the earth that is melting in the heat! Humanity must unite in the form of the highest consciousness based on intuition, which will provide free spaces for anyone to express herself in her own format and cultural experience. Then she will discover art that liberates from the talons of the shackles of the times!

Art must be able to free itself from the greedy claws of capital owners, from the manipulation of politicians who only employ power for their private interests or the interests of their group. Art must be free from all dogma and ideology. Art must stand independently and form an autonomous discourse and narrative — it must bring together different elements and possibilities so that a new awareness and a new sensitivity may break through the boundary walls and cut away the rope that binds imagination. An esthetics that stands on the culture of togetherness and the awareness of humanity and a new social perspective must be discovered! So a future that prioritizes a holistic life view that is sensitive to the

environment may be built! Fantasy and imagination must not be tripped over and rendered impotent only by economic calculations. The dignity of humankind and life is more than mere economic calculations and mathematical equations.

When the blind faith in the unreliable dogma of the market can be shattered — it will be possible to imagine a future full of hope. Not like our current situation, where in reality humankind finds it difficult to visualize a future. Optimism is imprisoned in a coffin! A creative person might know where the key to the coffin is hidden. She might free the optimism which will then transform into the courage to say NO to every form of destruction of nature, greed, the disrespect to common sense and also to tyranny. She will clear the path and blaze the trail of change. She will release the shackles and the binds of fantasy and imagination and let them fly free and become the future of all the inhabitants of this planet earth. She will become hope for those who still wish to continue life.

The "futurism" of this day will be based on a complete renewal of the awareness of humanity and justice. It will be a celebration of the arrivals of new, needed practical technologies and discoveries of new outlooks and new formulations and definitions in the field of science. The dynamics of "connections" between the elements of life will become a very important science (so that sciences will no longer be isolated in specialized boxes). And the artist will be the first person who must implement this knowledge in her esthetical concepts and her artistic practice. So art will be able to be present in the midst of life and find a correct reason to justify being there. Art will be a source of "enlightenment" — the artist will be a person who bears the torch in the frontline of the long and winding path of life.

Art must become the possession of all people. All elements who to date have been marginalized, the poor, the colored skinned, minorities and women, must be given a space and opportunities to produce and enjoy works of art. So it is not only those who have the means to purchase and those who have power over the bureaucracy who are free to enjoy and explore the products of creativity and monopolize production and distribution. Women, particularly, need not hide behind simplicity or the image of luxury to be able to express themselves. The real woman, the woman who represents the future, is the woman who stands on her own two feet and is capable of expressing and giving meaning to her own sexuality, eroticism, and her own reproductive system. She is also free to determine the form and meaning of her individual esthetics, such as determining her relationship with her partner in accordance to her desire and hopes based on the principle of mutual agreement.

In short, basically, the world and the esthetical values which to date have been controlled by very masculine powers and energies too much, must be balanced by the feminine. The phallus-centric era and the power of the patriarchy must be ended. The principle of androgyny will color life and art in the future. The fall of the World Trade Center in New York City, bombed and destructed by who-knows-who, is a sign that the financial system must be changed and the structure of the dominant thinking must be deconstructed. The system based on fossil fuels — those materials that have become the source of conflict — must be rethought and reanalyzed — alternative energy sources must take their place. If not the earth will burn to cinders and dry up, half its inhabitants will die of hunger. Art, no longer having any meaning, will be reduced to nauseating decoration.

Human beings will die but art should — as an age old adage says — be eternal. And to become eternal art must touch on things that are basic to life. Art must have the courage to leave everything that is established in its time, burst through the boundaries and enter the "unknown regions". The cultural jungle

of spectacles created by the system to render all the residents of earth impotent, to conquer them in order so that all obey and follow the rules of the "consumer society" must be passed through! So that the eyes that are swollen from lengthy weeping because of the disaster that has struck relentlessly will be able to see through and open the layers of shrouds of the mirage of reality. Art should function as a "means" with which to examine and assess reality. Art must be capable of fanning the spirit of liberation like a bonfire that never burns out!

For the people of Java when the earth is shaken by quakes and volcanoes cough and discharge flaming clouds, that is nature's reaction to something that is wrong in life. The earth is saddened and angry that humanity is only interested in extracting and consuming her wealth. Never wanting to nurture her let alone returning her kindness. Intellect is drowned in hot and toxic mud that has erupted over on to the surface of the earth because humankind does not care about the consequences of their actions. Creativity is only aimed at things that give immediate and temporary satisfaction. Artworks are manufactured and managed according to the mechanisms of a factory. Garbage esthetics are mass produced and pile up in gardens of artificial beauty. And serenaded by systematic hymns of seduction that penetrate the soul, humankind is forced to swallow that garbage. Humankind is being stoned by loneliness in the midst of the clamor of retinal sensations and consumer ecstasy, towards *moksa* and eternal nirvana.

(The future cannot be created without weighing what is happening now, even more by killing and denying the past).

July 2009.
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MANIFESTO OF THE SCEPTICS (2009)

ARAHMAIANI

Apparently, the term "contemporary art" triggers never ending discussions and debates — whether it is in a particular Indonesian context, or an Asian, or a worldwide context in general. A consequence of this is the effort to map the situation, with an assumption based on a theory of hegemony: The West dominates the rest! Maybe there is some truth in this, though if we look at the latest developments we should begin to think that slowly this theory is starting to crumble, to be taken to pieces.

Artists continuously discuss issues of identity, they question their "cultural position" in the global cultural formation and dialogue. Art practices reflect the effort to discover "identity" — this is obvious. But on the other hand the process of giving meaning to "identity" has also become extremely complicated — especially when it is challenged by the latest market system which can "devour" nearly every cultural product and turn it into a mere commodity!

The rapid development of information and communication technologies means that artists who live in the backwaters of a certain continent have the opportunity to create relationships with other artists in other parts of other continents. So the situation in which artists influence each other in styles of expression, ideas and concepts, is developing very fast. Connections in the virtual world and digital technology have made what was thought to be impossible, a reality.

These "new mediums" are being continuously developed — the potentials that have a "liberating" nature must be explored even further. Our current world which is controlled through the manipulations of images and spectacles can be "neutralized" with digital technology and the virtual world which are not so easy to place an ownership claim over. Technology has made anyone able to duplicate and multiply. This means that a centralized control is close to impossible to enforce, but control of power can be done and monopolies might become history!

So we continue our discussions, we try to give even further meaning to the idea of "an expanded definition of art" — expand it as wide as possible! We must explore work strategies so that art does not become a noose without us realizing it, without us feeling it, just because we are enthralled with the games and the pleasure of the visual sensations of the images that we create. Consciously or not we surrender to the flow of pleasure and we avoid issues and conflicts. Probably our excuse is that we don't want to create more problems or we don't want to hurt people's feelings.

True, we must avoid and even condemn any council to make war — to kill and destroy each other. But this doesn't mean that we must avoid conflict and difference in opinion. A democratic system should be able to accommodate and manage conflicts and differences in opinions. Conflicts and dissent do not have to be handled through a "security" approach and with the use of violence — dialog and negotiations in equality is the procedure to find solutions and solve problems.

While we were enwrapped in discussion suddenly it was as if wild waves began to toss us around while we were sailing, the earth shook without control. The thunderous sound from the bowels of the earth intensified the gripping atmosphere which was followed by completely uncontrollable panic! At that time the morning had just broken to greet the world, and the quiet of the youthful morning was ripped in an instance. Those who were already awake or had not yet gone to sleep scattered to avoid the buildings that were crumbling down. In less than 1 minute our district was devastated by an earthquake and 4000 lives were sent home to eternity!

(I was involved in a virtual discussion, thousands of kilometers away — suddenly I lost contact and connection)

Manifesto of the Sceptics :

1. Our art is an autonomous zone — a self standing discourse and narrative. It cannot be dictated to by the interests of the market, politics or religion. Businessmen, politicians and religious leaders are not creators of art!

2. Our art belongs to everyone — everyone has the right to express themselves. This means that artists should not surrender to the symbolic powers that determine the conditions and the classification of art.

3. Our art must not be separated from life and become mere decoration. Art must be able to encourage a new awareness of humanity and a new social consciousness.

4. Our art is not an object — art is a neutral medium with the function of offering alternative values, changing values, and also turning values upside down. So art is capable of forming new values and bringing down those which are established!

5. Our art is a type of "alchemical vessel" — a vessel that can combine the sacred and the profane in one discourse that is capable of uniting contradicting elements. It can create a meeting point between the material and the spiritual, between the masculine and the feminine.

6. Our art is a channel for creativity — like plumbing that supplies fresh water. And creativity, like water, is an active force that is the essence of life which births ideas and concepts. In other words, a liberating force!

7. Our art is a natural, sustainable process — sowing seed, germinating, and producing fruit.

8. Our art is a "tool" to examine and assess reality, and can be employed by anyone, anytime, and anywhere!

9. Our art connects the past, the present, and the future.

10. Our art is a combination of courage, rebellion, rational and moral intelligence, and the conscience.

11. Although we are orientated forward, our art remembers and considers the past and the present.

12. The definition of art must be expanded — as wide as it possibly can be!

Yogyakarta, July 2009.
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'Letter to Marinetti' and 'Manifesto of the Sceptics' reproduced courtesy of artist.

THE GUERRILLA GIRLS' GUIDE TO BEHAVING BADLY (which you have to do most of the time in the world as we know it) (2010)

GUERRILLA GIRLS

SCHOOL OF THE ART INSTITUTE OF CHICAGO
COMMENCEMENT ADDRESS
MAY 22 2010

I bet this is the first time a woman wearing a gorilla mask has ever given a commencement address. If this makes it into Ripley's *Believe it or Not*, the School of the Art Institute of Chicago should get an award for taking the leap. It's delicious that an anonymous, masked artist is speaking to you today, when the art world still clings to the outmoded idea that art has to be about the individual — one great genius after another, creating entirely original work, passing the mantle on to the next genius, forming a master narrative that tells the history of our culture. And, ok, these geniuses are mostly pale and mostly male. So, what are the rest of us, including the 67% of Art Institute students who happen to be female, to do?

In 1985, we got the idea to put up two posters on the streets of NY about the state of women artists in the New York Art world. It wasn't a pretty picture. But we had a philosophy about how to construct political art — to twist an issue around and present it in a way that hadn't been seen before.

Who knew that our work would cause all hell to break loose? Who knew it would cause a major crisis of conscience about diversity in the art world, a subject museums, collectors and critics had ignored and denied for a long, long time. Now, it's a no brainer.... you can't tell the story of a culture without all the voices in it. Who knew that those two posters would lead to hundreds of others, plus actions, billboards, sticker and books — not just about about art, but about women and people of color in the worlds of film, politics and pop culture. Who knew that 25 years later we — the agitating outsiders — would wind up inside the museums we criticize: the Art Institute, The Museum of Modern Art in NY, the Pompidou in Paris... and be speaking to all of you today. The Guerrilla Girls have been so lucky to do this work and we're so grateful that thousands of people all over the world, aged 8 to 80, write us each year telling us that we inspired them tobecome activists, too.

We were just a bunch of girls who couldn't put up and shut up. We saw something that needed to be done. And we figured out a way to do it. We didn't have a plan but we had attitude and a strategy. We know that each of you in the Class of 2010 want to do great creative work and have strategies and attitude, too. We know you want to be the best artists, designers, writers, administrators, architects, and educators you can be. But we also know that you want to do good in the world at the same time. We all have to.

We can't not.

So today, as you go out to transform the worlds of art, design, fashion,architecture, art history, writing, critical theory, etc, plus fields that haven't been invented yet, I want to share some things we learned along the way.

Presenting: **THE GUERRILLA GIRLS' GUIDE TO BEHAVING BADLY**

THE GUERRILLA GIRLS' GUIDE TO BEHAVING BADLY (which you have to do most of the time in the world as we know it) (2010)

GUERRILLA GIRLS

Be a loser. The world of art and design doesn't have to be an Olympics where a few win and everyone else is forgotten. Even though the art market and celebrity culture is set up to support the idea of hyper-competition and to make everyone but the stars feel like failures, there's also a world out there of artistic cooperation and collaboration that's not about raging egos. That's the one we joined, and the one you can join, too. Get beyond the outdated assumption that only a handful of you will "make it." Don't all waste your time running after the same few carrots.

Be impatient. Don't wait for a stamp of approval from the system. Don't wait around to be asked to dance. Claim your place. Put on your own shows, create your own companies, develop your own projects. To steal a phrase from the Dali Lama, "Be the change you want to see in the world." In other words, Be the artworld you want to take part in.

Be crazy. Political art that just points to something and says "this is bad" is like preaching to the choir. Try to change people's minds about issues. Do it in an outrageous, unforgettable way. A lot of people in the art and film world didn't believe things were as bad as we said they were and we brought them around....with facts, humor and a little fake fur. Here's a trick we learned: If you can get someone who disagrees with you to you to laugh at an issue, you have a hook into their brain. Once inside you have a better chance of changing their minds.

Be anonymous. You'd be surprised what comes out of your mouth when you're wearing a gorilla mask. We started wearing them to protect our careers, but soon realized it was one of the secrets of our success. Anonymous free speech is protected by the First Amendment. So join that long line of anonymous masked avengers, like Robin Hood, Batman, and of course, Wonder Woman.

Be an outsider. Maybe having a secret identity isn't for you. But even if you end up working inside the system, act like an outsider. Look for the understory, the subtext, the overlooked, and the downright unfair, then expose it. We've empowered lots of people inside museums, universities and film studios to jam their culture and dis their institutions.

Lead a double life. Be a split personality. Be two, three, four, five artists in one body, like me. I'm an artist / activist / writer / graphic designer. Be a hybrid. Hybrids are so green.

Just do one thing. If it works, do another. If it doesn't, try it another way. Over time, we promise you it will all add up to something effective and great. Don't be paralyzed because you can't do it all right away. Just keep on chipping away.

Don't make only FINE art. Make some cheap art that can be owned by everyone, like books and movies can.

Sell out. If people start paying attention to you, don't waste time wondering if you've lost your edge. Take your critique right inside the galleries and institutions to a larger audience. When our work appears at venerable venues like the Venice Biennale, the Tate Modern, or The National Gallery in DC, we get hundreds of letters from people saying they were blown away by our analysis of art and culture.

Give collectors, curators, and museum directors tough love: (Bear with me, this is a long rant.) It's a pity that public art museums have to compete with billionaire art investors to own significant artworks. And then depend on those investors to donate the works! It's outrageous that art by women and artists of color sold at auction bring 10-20% of the price of art by white males. It's unethical that wealthy art collectors who put lots of money in the art market can then become museum trustees, overseeing museums that in turn validate their investments. What a lousy way to write and preserve our history! If things continue like they're going, a hundred years from now, many museums will be showing only the white male version of art history, with a few tokens thrown in. You need to keep that from happening. Make sure that museums cast a wider net and collect the real story of our culture.

How can you deliver tough love to the art world? Demand ethical standards inside museums. No more insider trading. No more conflicts of interest! No more cookie cutter collections of Art That Costs The Most (Eli Broad, do you hear us?) While you're at it, give some tough love to design and architecture, where women and people of color face a crushing glass ceiling. And finally, educators out there, don't teach a history constructed by corrupt institutions. Write your own!

Complain, complain, complain. But be creative about it. Sure we've done 45 feet high banners and billboards all over the world. But here's some simpler things we've done: Put anti-film industry stickers in movie theatre bathrooms, insert fliers with facts about art world discrimination into books in museum stores, send anonymous postcards to museum directors. Want more ideas? How about attaching political hangtags to items in clothing stores, putting up street art or billboards across from your office, slapping stickers on fashion magazine covers. You can probably think up a million better ideas than we can.

Use the F word. Be a feminist. For decades the majority of art school graduates have been women. Your class is no exception. But after school, when you find a too-small number of women and people of color in your field, especially at the top, then you know there's got to be discrimination, conscious or unconscious, going on. Don't just put up with it, say something. We think its ridiculous that so many people who believe in the tenets of feminism have been brainwashed by negative stereotypes in the media and society and refuse to call themselves feminists. And guys, that means you, too. Time to man up, whether you're female, male, trans, etc. and speak up for women. Women's rights, civil rights, and gay, lesbian and trans rights are the great human rights movements of our time. There's still a long way to go.

And last, but not least, be a great ape.

In 1917, Franz Kafka wrote a short story titled 'A Report to An Academy', in which an ape spoke about what it was like to be taken into captivity by a bunch of educated, intellectual types. The published story ends with the ape tamed and broken by the stultified academics. But in an earlier draft, Kafka tells a different story. The ape ends his report by instructing other apes NOT to allow themselves to be tamed.

He says instead: "break the bars of your cages, bite a hole through them, squeeze through an opening…and ask yourself where do YOU want to go?”

Make that YOUR ending, not the tamed and broken one.

Oh...And don't forget to have some serious fun along the way!!!!

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The Guerrilla Girls, started in 1985, are 'feminist masked avengers in the tradition of anonymous do-gooders like Robin Hood, Wonder Woman and Batman. How do we expose sexism, racism and corruption in politics, art, film and pop culture? With facts, humor and outrageous visuals. We reveal the understory, the subtext, the overlooked, and the downright unfair.'
Their work includes the production of posters, t-shirts, artworks, books and speeches protesting sexism.

RELATIONAL FILMMAKING MANIFESTO (2010)

JULIE PERINI

Relational filmmakers do not make films about people.

Relational filmmakers make films with people.

Relational filmmakers do not interview subjects.

Relational filmmakers have conversations with other people.

Relational filmmakers do not know what the final film will look like.

Relational filmmakers make formal decisions that address the aesthetic, ethical, technical, and personal problems encountered throughout the making of the film.

Relational filmmakers do not adhere to established modes or conventions.

Relational filmmakers make films that are abstract, factual, and fictional, all at once.

Relational filmmakers do not fuck around with these tools of representation and power.

Relational filmmakers use their tools to experiment with new ways of being and to emancipate new forms of subjectivity.

Relational filmmakers believe that reality is the consequence of what we do together. Their films carry and conduct traces of this belief. Relational films are co-created through careful and playful interrogations of the roles performed by the people and materials involved with the film's production and reception: artists, subjects, passers-by, audiences, environments, ideas, and things.

First published in *INCITE! Journal of Experimental Media* Issue #2, *Radical Aesthetics* (ed.) Brett Kashmere, Fall 2010.

Copyright © Julie Perini.

Julie Perini borrowed Nicholas Bourriaud's idea of "relational aesthetics" [N. Bourriaud *Relational Aesthetics* (Paris: les presses du réel, 1998. English translation, 2002)] and adapted it here for a filmmaking practice to explain how her own work addresses traditions of non-fiction filmmaking and video art that are committed to experimentation and destabilization, and pursue investigations into liveness and immediacy. See also Perini 'Relational Filmmaking: A Manifesto & Its Explication' in *Afterimage: The Journal of Media Arts and Cultural Criticism* (Rochester, New York) where she discusses the Relational Filmmaking Manifesto in greater detail, with reference to her 2010 video, *Girl Next Door*.

ECOSEX MANIFESTO (2011)

ELIZABETH M. STEPHENS and ANNIE M. SPRINKLE

(i) WE ARE THE ECOSEXUALS.
The Earth is our lover. We are madly, passionately, and fiercely in love, and we are grateful for this relationship each and every day. In order to create a more mutual and sustainable relationship with the Earth, we collaborate with nature. We treat the Earth with kindness, respect and affection.

(ii) WE MAKE LOVE WITH THE EARTH.
We are aquaphiles, terraphiles, pyrophiles and aerophiles. We shamelessly hug trees, massage the earth with our feet, and talk erotically to plants. We are skinny dippers, sun worshippers and stargazers. We caress rocks, are pleasured by waterfalls and admire the Earth's curves often. We make love to the Earth through our senses. We celebrate our E-spots. We are very dirty.

(iii) WE ARE A RAPIDLY GROWING GLOBAL COMMUNITY OF ECOSEXUALS.
This community includes artists, academics, sex workers, sexologists, healers, environmental activists, nature fetishists, gardeners, business people, therapists, lawyers, peace activists, eco-feminists, scientists, educators, (r)evolutionaries, critters and other entities from all walks of life. Some of us are SexEcologists, researching and exploring the places where sexology and ecology intersect in our culture. As consumers we aim to buy less. When we must, we buy green, organic and local. Whether on farms, at sea, in the woods, or in small towns or large cities, we connect and empathize with nature.

(iv) WE ARE ECOSEX ACTIVISTS.
We will save the mountains, waters and skies by any means necessary, especially through love, joy and our powers of seduction. We will stop the rape, abuse and the poisoning of the Earth. We do not condone the use of violence, although we recognize that some ecosexuals may choose to fight those most guilty for destroying the Earth with public disobedience, anarchist and radical environmental activist strategies. We embrace the revolutionary tactics of art, music, poetry, humor, and sex. We work and play tirelessly for Earth justice and global peace. Bombs hurt.

(v) ECOSEXUAL IS AN IDENTITY.
For some of us being ecosexual is our primary (sexual) identity, whereas for others it is not. Ecosexuals can be GLBTQI, heterosexual, asexual, and/or Other. We invite and encourage ecosexuals to come out. We are everywhere. We are polymorphous and pollen-amorous. We educate people about ecosex culture, community and practices. We hold these truths to be self evident; that we are all part of, not separate from, nature. Thus all sex is ecosex.

(vi) THE ECOSEX PLEDGE.

I promise to love, honor and cherish you Earth, until death brings us closer together forever.

VIVA LA ECOSEX REVOLUCION!

JOIN US.

Elizabeth M. Stephens and Annie M. Sprinkle's website is Sexecology.org.

Copyright © Elizabeth M. Stephens and Annie M. Sprinkle.

Annie Sprinkle's one woman show *Post-Porn Modernist* (1989) inspired the 'Post Porn Modernist Manifesto'(1989) written by Veronica Vera for the show's program.

80 : 20 (2011)

LUCIA TKACOVA and ANETTA MONA CHISA

20% of reasons not to be here:

— invisibility is resistance
— not to decorate the gardens of the white male
— because jan verwoert said "forget the national" and we like him
— venice biennale = showroom of western hegemony
— guilt
— not to jeopardize our place on the barricades
— art = revolution = spectacle = capital
— because we are 1 communist + 1 socialist feminist
— antinomadism
— venice biennale is a choking-on-money mercantilist fossil
— the zoo effect
— we have nothing to wear for the opening
— it's easier to criticize a show when you're not in it
— the curse of boosted expectations (2nd novel syndrome)
— to keep off who's hot & who's not
— tourist menu sucks
— to make art the way we feel, without considering its potential to succeed

80 % of reasons to be here:

— salami tactics within the art concern
— to fight the way the world map is folded
— confrontation, verification, gratification
— to hike up our price
— to score
— to be scene&herd
— romance in the air
— to spritz the day off
— good excuse for massive outfit shopping
— + on artfacts
— to hit all the cool parties
— performing history

— to pussify the biennale
— to have the chance to say all of this out

Copyright © Anetta Mona Chisa and Lucia Tkacova.

Anetta Mona Chisa & Lucia Tkacova's 80:20 mural was created for the facade of the Romanian Pavilion in Giardini di Castello, Venezia 2011 on the occasion of their participation for Romania. The words were painted in white in two lists on either side of the entrance to the pavilion. The list parodies Pareto's principle or the 80/20 rule of a vital few (20%) and a trivial many (80%) (which Pareto had used to discuss the unequal distribution of wealth in economic terms). In management circles, Pareto's principle also refers to how 20% of effort, time or attention may produce 80% of your results, and to prioritise "smart" or more productive ways of working or a business style about how to make decisions about time/effort.

MANIFESTA (2013)

SILVIA ZIRANEK

ART
ART!
ART?..... ART!!!
MORE.....
MORE ART, MORE ARTISTS, MORE MEANS, MORE WAYS, MORE GOOD,
MORE LIFE
MORE QUALITY THROUGH FEMALE QUANTITY
MORE NOW
MAKE ART NOW
MAKE GOOD ART
MAKE GOOD ART NOW
MAKE MORE ART NOW
MAKE MORE GOOD ART OURS NOW
MAKE OUR ART
MAKE NOW ART
DO THE MAKING, DO THE MATHS, DO THE DO
DID IT, AM DOING IT, SHALL DO, SHALL HOPE TO DO TO BE
BE THE DO, BE THE DOING, BE THE ART, BE THE NOW, BE THE MAKE
JUST BE
JUST BEING
JUST ART
JUST OUR ART
JUST US
JUST NOW
BE NOW
ART NOW
ART...
ART!

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An early version of this previously unpublished manifesto was printed by Crescent Arts, Scarborough, for The Art Party, November 2013.
See also Silvia Ziranek *Wall Works: Selected Writings and Performances* (KT press ebook, 2013).

THE MUNDANE AFROFUTURIST MANIFESTO (2013)

MARTINE SYMS

The undersigned, being alternately pissed off and bored, need a means of speculation and asserting a different set of values with which to re-imagine the future. In looking for a new framework for black diasporic artistic production, we are temporarily united in the following actions.

The Mundane Afrofuturists recognize that:

We did not originate in the cosmos.

The connection between Middle Passage and space travel is tenuous at best.

Out of five hundred thirty-four space travelers, fourteen have been black. An all-black crew is unlikely.

Magic interstellar travel and/or the wondrous communication grid can lead to an illusion of outer space and cyberspace as egalitarian.

This dream of utopia can encourage us to forget that outer space will not save us from injustice and that cyberspace was prefigured upon a “master/slave” relationship.

While we are often Othered, we are not aliens.

Though our ancestors were mutilated, we are not mutants.

Post-black is a misnomer.

Post-colonialism is too.

The most likely future is one in which we only have ourselves and this planet.

The Mundane Afrofuturists rejoice in:

Piling up unexamined and hackneyed tropes, and setting them alight.

Gazing upon their bonfire of the Stupidities, which includes, but is not exclusively limited to:

Jive-talking aliens;

Jive-talking mutants;

Magical negroes;

Enormous self-control in light of great suffering;

Great suffering as our natural state of existence;

Inexplicable skill in the martial arts;

Reference to Wu Tang;

Reference to Sun Ra;

Reference to Parliament Funkadelic and/or George Clinton;

Reference to Janelle Monáe;

Obvious, heavy-handed allusions to double-consciousness;

Desexualized protagonists;

White slavery;

Egyptian mythology and iconography;

The inner city;

Metallic colors;

Sassiness;

Platform shoes;

Continue at will…

We also recognize:

The harmless fun that these and all the other Stupidities have brought to millions of people.

The harmless fun that burning the Stupidities will bring to millions of people.

The imaginative challenge that awaits any Mundane Afrofuturist author who accepts that this is it: Earth is all we have. What will we do with it?

The chastening but hopefully enlivening effect of imagining a world without fantasy bolt-holes: no portals to the Egyptian kingdoms, no deep pes to Drexciya, no flying Africans to whisk us off to the Promised Land.

The possibilities of a new focus on black humanity: our science, technology, culture,

politics, religions, individuality, needs, dreams, hopes, and failings.

The surge of bedazzlement and wonder that awaits us as we contemplate our own cosmology of blackness and our possible futures.

The relief of recognizing our authority. We will root our narratives in a critique of normative, white validation. Since “fact” and “science” have been used throughout history to serve white supremacy, we will focus on an emotionally true, vernacular reality.

The understanding that our “twoness” is inherently contemporary, even futuristic. DuBois asks how it feels to be a problem. Ol’ Dirty Bastard says “If I got a problem, a problem’s got a problem ’til it’s gone.”

An awakening sense of the awesome power of the black imagination: to protect, to create, to destroy, to propel ourselves towards what poet Elizabeth Alexander describes as “a metaphysical space beyond the black public everyday toward power and wild imagination.”

The opportunity to make sense of the nonsense that regularly—and sometimes violently—accents black life.

The electric feeling that Mundane Afrofuturism is the ultimate laboratory for worldbuilding outside of imperialist, capitalist, white patriarchy.

The sense that the rituals and inconsistencies of daily life are compelling, dynamic, and utterly strange.

Mundane Afrofuturism opens a number of themes and flavors to intertextuality, double entendre, politics, incongruity, polyphony, and collective first-person—techniques that we have used for years to make meaning.

The Mundane Afrofuturists promise:

To produce a collection of Mundane Afrofuturist literature that follows these rules:

No interstellar travel—travel is limited to within the solar system and is difficult, time consuming, and expensive.

No inexplicable end to racism—dismantling white supremacy would be complex, violent, and have global impact.

No aliens unless the connection is distant, difficult, tenuous, and expensive—and they have no interstellar travel either.

No internment camps for blacks, aliens, or black aliens.

No Martians, Venusians, etc.

No forgetting about political, racial, social, economic, and geographic struggles.

No alternative universes.

No revisionist history.

No magic or supernatural elements.

No Toms, Coons, Mulattoes, or Bucks.

No time travel or teleportation.

No Mammies, Jezebels, or Sapphires.

Not to let Mundane Afrofuturism cramp their style, as if it could.

To burn this manifesto as soon as it gets boring.

— **Martine Syms & whomever will join me in the future of black imagination**.

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